

VULTURE CONSERVATION

2.4-km gap between life and death in Dehradun

Relocating carcass dumping site away from high-tension power infrastructure has improved raptors' survival rate

NEWS » PAGE 5



U.S. to control 65 billion barrels of Venezuela's oil: Trump

WORLD » PAGE 12



Why is Meta's \$17.1-billion settlement significant?

FAQ » PAGE 8



Injured Neeraj out of Asian Games and rest of the season

SPORT » PAGE 14

INSIDE



37 killed in blast following Russian strike near Kyiv

KYIV
Russia struck an arms depot near Kyiv, sparking fires and explosions that killed 37 people and wounded dozens of others, authorities said on Saturday. The attack was the second to hit a depot storing ammunition near Kyiv in less than two months. » PAGE 12

PM in Uzbekistan ahead of the SCO summit

TASHKENT
Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Saturday arrived in Tashkent, the capital of Uzbekistan, where he will hold delegation-level talks with President Shavkat Mirziyoyev, aiming to further strengthen the strategic partnership between the two countries. Mr. Modi was received by Mr. Mirziyoyev on arrival. » PAGE 3

Revanth seeks time for revision of electoral rolls

HYDERABAD
Telangana Chief Minister A. Revanth Reddy on Saturday urged the Election Commission of India to extend the claims and objections period for the SIR of electoral rolls in the State by four weeks, citing concerns over the number of voters flagged for verification and the possibility of electors being left out. » PAGE 2

SIA reiterates commitment to Air India

MUMBAI
With questions being raised about Air India's (AI) future amid losses, Singapore Airlines reiterated its commitment to AI in which it holds 25.1% stake. It said investment in AI received the attention of its board and any requests for additional capital would be evaluated. » PAGE 11

File FIR over Haldwani ritual, Rahul tells Modi

NEW DELHI
Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on Saturday attacked the BJP and RSS over an alleged *shuddhikaran* ceremony at the venue of Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge's Haldwani rally this month. He demanded that PM ensure an FIR against those responsible. » PAGE 4

Rescue efforts on a war footing in Nepal as disaster toll hits 675

167 Indian nationals rescued; nearly 2,500 still missing in the last two days, 279 people rescued from hydropower tunnels while India, China dispatch tunnel rescue experts as over 900 people working with 11 hydropower projects remain missing



Amid the ruins: A drone view of the aftermath of flash floods at the confluence of the Trishuli and Tadi rivers in Devighat, Nuwakot district, Nepal, on Saturday. AP

Sanjeev Satgainya
KATHMANDU

The death toll from Nepal's devastating flash flood rose to 675 on Saturday, as authorities said rescue operations continued for a fourth day, though hindered by the remoteness of the region. The country's National Disaster Risk Reduction and Management Authority (NDRRMA) said at least 2,498 people remained missing, while more than 7,514 had been rescued. According to the Nepal Tourism Board (NTB), 261 tourists have been rescued, including 167 from India and 40 from China. There were eight people from Ukraine, four from Malta, and three from the U.S., apart from 21 unidentified people who were al-

so brought to safety. According to the NDRRMA, more than 900 people associated with 11 hydropower projects, including those under construction, remain unaccounted for. It said that in the last two days, 279 people were rescued from hydropower tunnels and hundreds more are believed to be trapped in tunnels as well, creating a daunting challenge for rescuers. A tunnel rescue team from India reached Nepal on Saturday with specialised machinery, in accordance with an earlier reconnaissance team sent on Friday, India's Ministry of External Affairs said. China also dispatched five tunnel experts on Saturday, who landed directly in the disaster-affected area.

Nepal Foreign Minister Shishir Khanal dismissed reports that Nepal had rejected international assistance and support, saying that the government had requested specific and specialised assistance "from our friendly neighbours to strengthen search-and-rescue efforts, particularly in the tunnels." Six teams of Indian forensic experts are also expected to reach Nepal this weekend, to help identify mortal remains that are being recovered in the disaster-hit areas, the MEA said. In a social media post, Nepal Prime Minister Balendra Shah said that DNA and other evidence of identification would be preserved for bodies that cannot be identified. "Bodies identified by families would be handed over to

them," he said, adding that 18,708 security personnel have been mobilised in the flood-affected areas. Authorities have been continuously monitoring river systems and downstream flood risks, with agencies placed on high alert. Meanwhile, authorities struggled to manage the bodies washed up in Chitwan district, downstream from the flood-affected Bhotekoshi-Trishuli river system. According to district authorities in Chitwan, as many as 229 unidentified bodies were being kept at holding centres and health institutions. Helpline numbers The Embassy of India in Kathmandu said it is working closely with Nepali authorities, including the

Nepal Police, to ensure that the mortal remains of Indian nationals can be handed over to the next of kin after identification. The embassy has provided helpline numbers and an email ID for those seeking information: +977 985 131 6807, +977 970 910 7500, +977 981 032 6117, and eoi-kathmandufloodsupport@gmail.com. The Government of Nepal has been releasing photographs and descriptions of the deceased. Information related to the identification of mortal remains from the recent flash flood can be accessed through the short URL: newsth.live/Nepal (Inputs from Kallol Bhattacharjee in New Delhi)

A HIMALAYAN TRAGEDY
» PAGE 9

Not a good sign if a Bar Council loses respect: SC judge

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

Supreme Court judge Justice B.V. Nagarathna said it is not a good sign if a Bar Council, whether at the Central or State level, loses the respect of its members. The senior judge was speaking at the 13th convocation of National Law University Delhi on Saturday. "The Bar Councils, whether the Central or the States, must introspect on their role and importance in upholding professional ethics, morality and professional competence. When a Bar Council does not earn the respect of its members, it is not a good sign for the legal profession," she said.

NALSAR row Her words gain added resonance following the recent public outrage and pushback from the legal fraternity over an aborted attempt by the Bar Council of India (BCI) and its long-standing chairperson and senior advocate Manan Kumar Mishra to restrict the 2026 graduating batch of NALSAR University of Law, Hyderabad, from professional enrolment. The students had objected to inviting Chief Justice of India Surya Kant as the chief guest for the convocation, reportedly taking offence to his oral remarks peppered with terms like 'cockroaches' and 'parasites' in the court room. Even the CJI took strong exception to the BCI's intervention, calling it an "unwarranted interference". He had said the BCI had no business whatsoever to come between him and NALSAR students who were only exercising their right to protest. Addressing graduating students, faculty and guests at the convocation, Justice Nagarathna said the legal profession was a liberal pursuit in the truest



The Bar Councils, whether the Central or the States, must introspect on their role and importance in upholding professional ethics, morality and professional competence



Justice B.V. NAGARATHNA

sense of the word. "Its institutions – courts, tribunals, the Bar, law schools – are among the places in which disagreements can have a civilised implication," she said. Ms. Nagarathna underscored the importance of legal professionals safeguarding their profession from outside pulls, pressures and preferences. She said the responsibility to preserve the autonomy of the legal profession lies with the lawyers. "The independence of the Bar is not an entitlement given to lawyers for their own benefit... Lawyers are safety valves of democracies," she said. **Lawyers should adapt** The judge stressed the importance of adaptability for lawyers of the 21st century. "You are entering a profession that must constantly adapt and respond to a changing reality. The velocity of change around us is unprecedented – technological advancements, environmental crises, social upheavals, geopolitical shifts, and transformations in the way we live, work, and think. These are not theoretical conundrums. They go to the heart of what kind of society we want to live in – and what role the law should play in shaping it," she said.

T.N. to set up safe houses for vulnerable inter-caste couples

Activists say courts should monitor these shelters to be set up in all districts; they will offer lifeline for couples and survivors facing threats

Dennis S. Jesudasan
CHENNAI

When a couple goes against their parents' wishes to get married, they often need immediate refuge, especially if they cross caste or religious lines. The Tamil Nadu government's recent plan to set up a 'safe house' in each district offers a lifeline for individuals and families vulnerable to caste killings and related

types of violence. "If only we had such a safe house earlier, I would not have lost my husband Shankar," said activist Kausalya Shankar, welcoming the "historic" decision. Announcing the plan in the State Assembly on Friday, Social Justice Minister Vanni Arasu said it was in line with the Supreme Court's ruling in the *Shakti Vahini vs. Union of India* case, and followed representations from survivors of caste-related killings and activists.

"When a groom is murdered in an 'honour' killing and the bride survives, she is thrust into a state of utter devastation and helplessness," said anti-caste activist and filmmaker Geeta Ilango. "While a surviving groom in a similar tragedy might eventually find a way to move on, a surviving bride faces a harrowing reality," she said, noting that a safe house would let her "rebuild her livelihood, and fearlessly pursue her

legal battle for justice." Activist Evidence Kathir offered a note of caution. "It should be ensured that the space is not used to hold talks with the couples to persuade them to end their marriage. The safe house should be under the direct monitoring of the courts," he said. He noted that the State had set up special cells with a helpline to file complaints in this regard as early as 2018. However, they were not functioning properly, he said.



India and China yet to announce meeting sites

Vijaita Singh
NEW DELHI

India and China are yet to announce the locations of two additional Border Personnel Meeting (BPM) points along the Line of Actual Control. However, government sources said that at least two rounds of meetings have been held over the past year.

FULL REPORT
» PAGE 3



MDMA packets seized by the police in Kerala.

MDMA worth ₹10 cr. seized in Kerala; three arrested

The Hindu Bureau
MALAPPURAM

A police squad from Malappuram in Kerala seized 12.8 kg of MDMA valued at more than ₹10 crore from a car in Coimbatore. Three persons from Malappuram and Wayanad were arrested.

The arrested were Jabir Ali, 32, from Panthallur near Manjeri; Mohammed Salih, 34, from Meppadi in Wayanad; and Shaim Akbar, 21, from Anakkayam near Manjeri.

The arrests were made by a special investigation team led by district police chief Chaitra Teresa John. Manjeri Inspector T.G. Di-leep and the District Anti-Narcotics Special Action Force (DANSAF) squad were part of the team.

The police said the MDMA was being transported for distribution in Kerala and Tamil Nadu. The drugs were concealed in the door panels of an In-nova car.

The MDMA was packed in quantities ranging from 100 to 500 g for delivery at multiple locations in Kerala, the police said.

Revanth seeks 4 more weeks for revision of electoral rolls

Nearly one-third of Telangana electorate have to prove their eligibility, says Chief Minister in letter to CEC Gyanesh Kumar; govt. apprehensive that a large number of voters will be left out of the list

R. Ravikanth Reddy
HYDERABAD

Telangana Chief Minister A. Revanth Reddy on Saturday urged the Election Commission of India to extend the claims and objections period for the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls in the State by four weeks, citing concerns over the large number of voters flagged for verification and the possibility of eligible electors being left out.

In a letter to Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar, Mr. Reddy said the revision had reached a critical stage, with nearly one-third of the State's electorate potentially required to estab-



In his letter to the CEC, Revanth Reddy proposed many safeguards, including public reading of draft electoral rolls. SIDDHANT THAKUR

lish their eligibility afresh.

ASDD classification

According to the letter, against the State's electoral roll of 3.38 crore electors as of June 10, around 73.39

lakh entries have been placed under the categories of Absent, Shifted, Dead and Duplicate (ASDD). Of the 2.65 crore enumeration forms digitised so far, 60.5 lakh have

been flagged for anomalies and another 32.36 lakh for lack of a link to the previous electoral roll. The two categories are distinct, taking the total number of electors requiring notice to 92.86 lakh, the letter said.

Mr. Reddy expressed concern over the ASDD classification, noting that 45.19 lakh, or nearly 62% of the 73.39 lakh ASDD entries, had been classified as 'permanently shifted'.

Besides seeking a four-week extension of the claims and objections period, currently scheduled from August 17 to September 16, with final publication on October 19, the Chief Minister proposed several safeguards, including public reading of draft electoral rolls.

Vijay says ₹10 lakh Thaman payment claim is conjectural

Mohamed Imranullah S.
CHENNAI

DMK candidate R.D. Shekar, who had lost in the Perambur Assembly constituency and filed an election petition, has failed to submit materials to prove that music composer S. Thaman was paid ₹10 lakh to compose the Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam's election campaign song "Thani oruvan vedichu varaan, visillu onnu adichu varaan," Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay has told the Madras High Court.

In an affidavit filed in support of his application to reject the election petition, Mr. Vijay highlighted that the election petitioner had only claimed to have "reasonably learnt" that the composer Ghantasala Sai Srinivas, professionally known as Thaman, "would have charged ₹10 lakh." Therefore, the claim of such a payment having been made was "purely conjectural".

"The election petition does not plead that ₹10 lakh was actually paid, incurred or authorised," the affidavit read.

Mr. Vijay said, similarly, the election petition does not rely upon any material with precision to prove the other alleged expenses incurred by him over and above the statutory ceiling of ₹40 lakh during the course of campaigning.

Foreign contributor

He also contended that the election petition does not plead the identity of any



C. Joseph Vijay

foreign contributor or the amount of the alleged foreign contribution received for the election campaign.

The court was also told that the election petitioner had failed to establish how the loans offered by the Chief Minister to his children and whether that money was reflected in their income tax returns or not had materially affected the result of the election in which the petitioner had lost by a margin of 53,715 votes with Mr. Vijay securing 1,20,365 votes as against 66,650 votes secured by the petitioner.

He also stated that his mere physical presence in places of worship during the election campaign could not be termed as a corrupt practice. "Section 83(1)(b) of the Representation of the People Act, 1951 requires full particulars in respect of a corrupt practice. But the election petition does not set out the words constituting the religious appeal, the precise communication, the audience or electors to whom it was addressed," he said.

Cong. expels DCC member for blocking Satheesan's motorcade

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

Chenthi Anil, the District Congress Committee (DCC) member who was arrested by the police on Saturday for stopping Keralam Chief Minister V.D. Satheesan's convoy, has been expelled from the party.

Thiruvananthapuram DCC president N. Sakthan expelled Mr. Anil from the primary membership of the party, even as the district-level leader was remanded in judicial custody for 14 days on Saturday.

Mr. Sakthan told *The Hindu* that blocking the Chief Minister's vehicle cannot be justified under any circumstance.

Mr. Anil, along with a group of people, had allegedly blocked the convoy and misbehaved with Mr. Satheesan for declining to attend the Sree Narayana Guru Jayanti celebrations planned at Chenthi here.

Following the incident on Friday evening, police had registered an FIR against Mr. Anil and had taken him into custody on Saturday.

Sources in the Chief Minister's office said Mr. Satheesan had been advised against attending the event based on intelligence inputs and that his office had informed the organisers a week ago that he would be unable to attend.

Speaking to reporters on Saturday, Home Minister Ramesh Chennithala said the law will take its course.

Court pulls up DCP for illegal detention

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

Taking serious note of an illegal detention by Whitefield police in Bengaluru, the High Court of Karnataka on Saturday summoned and pulled up Deputy Commissioner of Police (DCP) Saidulu Adavath for curtailing personal liberty of citizens.

Questioning how the police can arrest or detain persons illegally, that too contrary to the apex court's judgments and

right under the nose of the State Police Chief, the High Court ordered the Director-General and Inspector General of Police to issue guidelines making it clear to the police that illegal arrest/detention would attract disciplinary proceedings against them.

Justice M. Nagaprasanna issued the directions on a petition filed by Mohan Gowda of Hindu Rashtra Samanvaya Samithi.

The Whitefield police had *suo motu* registered a case against him for pu-

blishing a Facebook post celebrating the cancellation of a show by stand-up comedian Kunal Kamra. In the post, Mr. Gowda had termed the cancellation "a victory for Hindu unity" as the Samithi had given representation to the police against allowing the show in Whitefield.

The court noted that the police registered the case on August 4, and the very next day, a police team had brought the petitioner to Whitefield in his car. Interestingly, the court noted,

the police, a few yards away from the station, served him with a notice dated August 5/6, 2026, which, in fact, had given him the next three days to appear before them for questioning. The court found it to be a blatant violation as the petitioner himself was in their custody even before the notice landed on his hands.

"You can't take the liberty of citizens for granted just because you are in a uniform..." the High Court orally told the DCP.

INBRIEF



Medical college in Karnataka to be named after Hegde

Karnataka Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar on Saturday announced that the proposed medical college in Uttara Kannada, the home district of former Chief Minister Ramakrishna Hegde, and a major road in the Shivaram Karanth Layout in Bengaluru, would be named after the late leader. On the occasion of Hegde's birth centenary celebrations, Mr. Shivakumar recalled his contribution to decentralisation and education in Karnataka. Vice-President C.P. Radhakrishnan termed Hegde a statesman and a nationalist.

Idukki policeman suspended for sharing 'anti-Muslim' post

Idukki District Police Chief A. Naseem suspended a police officer on Friday night for sharing an 'anti-Muslim' post on Facebook. The suspended official is a grade sub-inspector (SI). He had shared a viral video depicting the ruining of an *Athapoakkalam* (flower carpet), along with comments allegedly targeting the Muslim community. Muslim Youth League filed a complaint with the police over this. Mr. Naseem, subsequently directed the Thodupuzha Deputy Superintendent of Police to conduct an inquiry. Based on the findings, the SI was suspended.

A.P. Police bust inter-State burglary gang; six arrested

The Andhra Pradesh Police on Saturday arrested six members of an inter-State gang allegedly involved in 13 theft cases, and recovered valuables worth around ₹60 lakh. Anantapur Superintendent of Police P. Jagadish said 393 grams of gold, 100 grams of silver and ₹1.49 lakh in cash were recovered from the accused. According to the police, the gang allegedly targeted victims by posing as passengers before stealing handbags from crowded areas.

A grand finale



Bringing the curtains down on Onam celebrations, people dressed like big cats take to the streets of Thrissur, Kerala, during the city's famed *Pulikkali* performance, on Saturday. Amid cheering crowds, about 450 people took part in the annual spectacle. K.K. NAJEEB

Youth body prepares over 1 lakh bamboo seed balls, sets record

The Hindu Bureau
VIJAYAWADA

The Confederation of Indian Industry's (CII) Young Indians (Yi) Chapter in Amaravati set a new record in the Asia Book of Records for the maximum number of native bamboo seed balls prepared by a youth organisation, with 1,13,109 seed balls prepared in a single day at the P.B. Siddhartha College of Arts & Science here on Saturday.

Empowering youth

The initiative was aimed at promoting climate action, afforestation, volunteerism and ecological responsibility, according to a

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press release.

The Yi Chapter in Andhra Pradesh capital Amaravati said the initiative was part of its efforts to engage and empower young people to contribute meaningfully to nation-building.

The seed ball preparation drive was undertaken as a tangible step towards environmental conservation and sustainable development.

Illegal trekking and 'hidden spot' tourism raise alarm in Karnataka's Western Ghats

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

Residents and environmentalists across the Western Ghats, particularly in Kodagu and Chikkamagaluru districts of Karnataka have raised concerns over the growing trend of tour operators promoting hidden and remote natural spots for trekking and adventure activities.

Residents fear that the sudden influx of tourists in ecologically fragile areas could cause irreversible damage to forests, water sources, and wildlife habitats. They allege treks are being organised to these spots without permission from the Forest Department.



Crowd puller: Social media is abuzz with videos of tourists flocking to see *Neelakurinji* in bloom across the Western Ghats. FILE PHOTO

The increased footfall has resulted in tourists leaving behind plastic waste and other garbage, they said.

Sensitive ecology

In Kodagu, the Forest Department recently intensified action against unauthorised commercial

AIMIM asks MLC Mirza Rahmat Baig to resign from party

The Hindu Bureau
HYDERABAD

The All India Majlis-e-Ittehadul Muslimeen expelled Member of Telangana Legislative Council (MLC) Mirza Rahmat Baig from the party on Friday night.

As per its announcement, Mr. Baig has been instructed to tender his resignation to the Chairman of the Legislative Council.

While the reason for the decision was not stated, insiders said the MLC was found in a state of indiscipline, of which the party leadership took a very serious view.

On Saturday, Mr. Baig

removed pictures of AIMIM chief Asaduddin Owaisi from his X account banner photo. He also deleted references to both the party and the Hyderabad parliamentarian from his bio. Earlier, he had approached the police alleging that certain persons were threatening to release deepfakes to tarnish his reputation. He maintained innocence and said that there was a conspiracy to cast aspersions on him.

The expulsion came soon after this.

The Hindu tried to reach Mr. Baig for comments. However, his phone remained out of reach.

PM in Uzbekistan for 2-day visit ahead of SCO summit

While in Tashkent, Modi will hold delegation-level talks with Uzbekistan President Shavkat Mirziyoyev; later, he will head to Bishkek in the Kyrgyz Republic to participate in the SCO summit

Press Trust of India
TASHKENT

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Saturday arrived in Tashkent, the capital of Uzbekistan, where he will hold delegation-level talks with President Shavkat Mirziyoyev, aiming to further strengthen the strategic partnership between the two countries.

Mr. Modi was received by Mr. Mirziyoyev on arrival at the airport on his fourth visit to the nation. This is the first leg of the Prime Minister's two-nation visit to Uzbekistan and the Kyrgyz Republic, focusing on strengthening India's strategic partnerships in Central Asia and deepening the civilisational connect with the region.

During his two-day visit to Uzbekistan, Mr. Modi will discuss several bilateral agendas including trade and defence with Mr. Mirziyoyev. "I look forward to my discussions with President Mirziyoyev on further deepening our cooperation in trade and investment, digital connectivity, defence, energy, and on advancing our shared visions of 'Viksit Bharat' and 'Yangi Uzbekistan'," Mr.



Tashkent talks: PM Narendra Modi welcomed by Uzbekistan President Shavkat Mirziyoyev in Tashkent on Saturday. During the visit, the leaders are set to hold talks on digital connectivity and defence. ANI

Modi said in his departure statement. Mr. Modi said he would also visit the Shastri Memorial and the Mahatma Gandhi Centre at the Tashkent State University of Oriental Studies.

SCO summit

From Tashkent, the Prime Minister will travel to Bishkek, capital of Kyrgyzstan, to participate in the 26th Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) Summit, at the invitation of the President of the Kyrgyz Republic, Sadyr Zhaparov. Mr. Modi said in his departure

statement, "India has been an active and constructive member of the SCO since 2017. I look forward to advancing India's vision for the region, anchored in security, connectivity and opportunity, and to working with fellow members for a region free from the scourge of terrorism, separatism and extremism, which continue to threaten peace in our neighbourhood and beyond."

Officials said Mr. Modi will address the SCO summit, where he will highlight India's priorities of se-

curity, connectivity and opportunity. He will also hold bilateral meetings with SCO leaders on the sidelines of the summit, they said.

The Prime Minister also said he would attend the World Nomad Games.

"I also look forward to meeting President Zhaparov and other SCO leaders, and to attend the opening ceremony of the 6th World Nomad Games, a celebration of the rich living heritage of Central Asia that India holds in deep respect," he said.

Stakes high as India seeks to reset ties with Central Asian countries

NEWS ANALYSIS

Suhasini Haidar
NEW DELHI

Prime Minister Narendra Modi's four-day visit to Uzbekistan and the Kyrgyz Republic is more than just an outreach to two important states in Central Asia or the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO). The agenda will include engagements aimed at three additional multilateral platforms – the upcoming BRICS Summit in September, the two-year UN Security Council term of 2028-2029, and planning for the long-pending India-Central Asia Summit, which has not met since 2022. Experts say the delay has led to speculation in the region that New Delhi has lost interest in the engagement, particularly compared with Mr. Modi's first foray in 2015, when he visited all five Central Asian states.

His biggest challenge during this visit will be to reverse that perception.

In a speech given at Kazakhstan's Nazarbayev University in Nur Sultan, addressed to the "people of Central Asia", Mr. Modi had then promised that India would rebuild connectivity to the region. However, while trade in goods has risen from \$500 mil-

lion in 2010 to more than \$2 billion in 2025, connectivity prospects have been considerably cut due to geopolitical shifts.

The rupture in ties with Pakistan since 2016 has ended India's road connectivity to Afghanistan and Central Asia, as well as the Turkmenistan-Afghanistan-Pakistan-India pipeline. More recently, the virtual closure of the Chabahar port projects due to U.S. sanctions has ended that route, while the U.S.-Iran war has impelled the International North South Transport Corridor project. In addition, China's Belt and Road Initiative has made deep inroads in the region, growing to \$106 billion in China-Central Asia trade in 2025.

Bilateral focus

"The broader message is that we have to stay engaged with the entire region, but also bilaterally with each Central Asian state," Nandan Unnikrishnan, a distinguished fellow at the Observer Research Foundation and a leading expert on Central Asia and Russia, said, adding, "We may not be able to match China and Russia in terms of investment and influence, but we have many economic interests. In addition, India's soft power is in trade, education, and IT,

SCO summit will be Mr. Modi's first opportunity to meet Iran President since the U.S.-Iran war began and discuss over the Strait of Hormuz

where Indians have been slow to utilise such obvious advantages."

In Bishkek, Chinese President Xi Jinping and Russian President Vladimir Putin will attend the summit amongst other leaders of the SCO members. Kyrgyz President Sadyr Japarov will hand over the presidency of the SCO to Pakistan Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif for 2027, and all eyes will be on whether Mr. Modi gives any indication that he would attend the summit in Islamabad.

The SCO summit will also be Mr. Modi's first opportunity to meet with Iran President Masoud Pezeshkian since the U.S.-Iran war began, and discuss India's concerns over the Hormuz Strait blockade.

Seat contest

In addition, New Delhi wants Iran to take a more flexible position at the BRICS summit on September 12, where tensions between Iran and the UAE have held up consensus ov-

er a joint statement.

The next big hurdle Mr. Modi must cross is with Tajikistan, given that India and Tajikistan are both contenders for the Asian bloc's vote for the non-permanent seat in the UN Security Council election in June 2027. Despite India's considerably larger diplomatic footprint, recent votes in the UN General Assembly have delivered upsets – in June, Germany lost out to Portugal and Austria, and the Philippines lost to the Kyrgyz Republic in this year's UNSC votes.

In addition, Bangladesh's Khalilur Rahman defeated his rival from Cyprus for President of the General Assembly in a tight race, even though the U.S., European countries, and India are understood to have supported Cyprus. In the absence of a "clean slate" for next year's election, India's best bet would be to convince Tajikistan to put off its candidature to another year, and for Mr. Modi to discuss this with both Tajik President Emomali Rahmon and his Central Asian counterparts during the upcoming summit.

Finally, officials hope that a date for the India-Central Asia Summit, which has been put off several times, will be set during the PM's visit.

BJP worker in custody for copying SIR forms; 5 BLOs suspended

The Hindu Bureau
THANE/MUMBAI

Five booth-level officers (BLOs) have been suspended after a local BJP worker was caught on Thursday photocopying more than 3,400 Special Intensive Revision (SIR) electoral forms containing voters' photographs, personal details, and official BLO signatures at a shop in Navi Mumbai.

A case was filed on the morning of August 28, a senior Kharghar police official said.

"Electoral Registration Officers (EROs) were sent to investigate the complaint, where they caught Suraj Patil making illegal photocopies of 3,400 enumeration forms at a photocopy centre in Sector 19, Kharghar. The EROs registered the crime at Kharghar police station," District Collector Kishan Jawale said.

Five BLOs who were responsible for handing these enumeration forms to accused Suraj Patil, have been suspended, he said.

Prints seized

Kharghar police rushed to the scene and took the alleged BJP office-bearer into custody. All the printed enumeration forms were seized from the premises and taken to the police station.

According to police, Shiv Sena (UBT) workers confronted the man and claimed he was an office-bearer of the BJP's Youth Wing. Mr. Patil was detained and served a notice as per standard legal procedure before being released, police said. Sena (UBT) workers alleged that Mr. Patil managed to flee the Kharghar police station shortly after being brought in for questioning. The incident triggered a clash between Shiv Sena (UBT) and BJP activists. (With inputs from PTI)

India, China yet to announce 2 more border meeting points along LAC

Vijaita Singh
NEW DELHI

India and China are yet to announce the locations of two additional Border Personnel Meeting (BPM) points along the Line of Actual Control (LAC). However, government sources said that at least two rounds of meetings between local commanders of the two countries have been held at Kepang La in Arunachal Pradesh's Upper Siang district over the past year.

According to an eight-point outcome document released by both countries on August 26 following the 25th round of talks bet-



A file photo of Indian Army and Chinese PLA officers during a Border Personnel Meeting (BPM) at Chushul-Moldo in January 2020. ANI

ween the Special Representatives (SR) on the Boundary Question, India and China have also agreed to establish two additional meeting points to hold General-level or Senior Highest Military Comman-

der-level meetings.

India was represented at the talks by National Security Adviser (NSA) Ajit Doval, while China was represented by Wang Yi, Member of the Political Bureau of the Chinese Com-

munist Party Central Committee and Director of the Office of the Central Commission for Foreign Affairs.

At present, there are five BPMs in the western and eastern sectors. – Daulat Beg Oldie and Chushul in Ladakh, Nathu La in Sikkim and Kibithu and Bum La in Arunachal Pradesh.

According to a Ministry of Defence statement in 2019, the BPM mechanism has evolved into an important interface where local issues get discussed and resolved, thereby fostering confidence among the Border Guarding Troops. "This ensures prevalence of peace and tranquility along the LAC."

Kharge urges govt. to ensure safety of Indians in Nepal

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Congress president and Leader of the Opposition in the Rajya Sabha Mallikarjun Kharge has written to Prime Minister Narendra Modi, urging the government to provide humanitarian and relief assistance to flood-ravaged Nepal and intensify efforts to ensure the safety and evacuation of Indian nationals stranded there.

In his letter, dated August 28 and released on Saturday, Mr. Kharge urged the Prime Minister: "I request you to ensure that adequate humanitarian and relief assistance is provided to the affected peo-



Mallikarjun Kharge

ple of Nepal in coordination with the Government of Nepal".

'Deploy NDRF'

He also urged the Centre to issue necessary directions to intensify rescue and evacuation efforts and make arrangements for

their safe and early return to India.

In a separate letter to Union Home Minister Amit Shah, Mr. Kharge urged the government to consider extending "immediate and comprehensive" humanitarian and disaster-relief assistance to Nepal, and to treat the matter with "urgency and sensitivity", underlining the deep and enduring ties between the two countries.

He said the deployment of National Disaster Response Force (NDRF) teams, wherever required and in coordination with the Nepal government, should also be considered to assist in rescue, evacuation and relief operations.

Father, aide held for alleged murder of 38-year-old son

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

A 64-year-old man and his associate have been arrested in connection with murder of his 38-year-old son after luring him to an abandoned container in south-east Delhi on the pretext of taking him to a doctor, police said on Saturday.

The victim, Gul Hasan, was attacked with a concrete stone and later strangled. His body was found inside the abandoned container, locally known as "Bablu ka Container", in Kalindi Kunj on August 23.

The accused have been identified as Talukdar Ansari, the victim's father, and Md. Wasim alias Akram (49). Both were traced to a stitching factory in Govindpur after analysis of CCTV footage.

According to police, information about an unidentified male body was received on August 23. The

body was found inside the container adjacent to the NTPC wall, around 500 metres east of the Delhi-Mumbai Expressway.

A murder case was subsequently registered at Kalindi Kunj police station and four teams were formed to identify the victim and trace the accused. Investigators analysed CCTV footage from the area and adjoining locations and reconstructed the victim's movements. The footage eventually showed Hasan travelling towards the crime scene with two men.

Investigation revealed that Hasan had been diagnosed with schizophrenia. The accused took him to the abandoned container by telling him they were taking him to a doctor. There, Wasim attacked Hasan with a stone, and the two then strangled him using a rope made from cloth.

AI can aid healthcare, doctors must lead decisions, say experts

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Artificial intelligence (AI) is becoming an integral part of healthcare and is here to stay, but the skills, judgement and critical thinking of medical practitioners will remain central to patient care, experts said at a webinar on "The Future Doctor: Balancing Clinical Experience with Technology" organised by SRM Institute of Science and Technology, in association with The Hindu.

The panellists comprised R. Jayanthi, Dean, SRM Medical College Hospital and Research Centre; Vivek N, Dean (Dental), SRM Kattankulathur Dental College and Hospital; Ritubhan Gautam, Head - Global Health, Deep Tek.ai; and K. Ganapathy, Honorary Distinguished Professor, IIM Jammu.

Distinguished Professor, Tamil Nadu Dr. M.G.R. Medical University, and Emeritus Professor, National Academy of Medical



Sciences. Dr. Jayanthi said AI has become an important part of healthcare and medical education, and doctors and institutions must adapt to the AI era.

She stressed the need for medical students to develop AI literacy and a strong "verification reflex", ensuring that AI-generated information does not undermine clinical reasoning and critical thinking.

AI with responsibilities

AI should support clinical decisions, but doctors should never outsource their responsibility to the technology, said Dr. Ganapathy.

He underlined the importance of strengthening judgement and accountability, and of asking the

right clinical questions while assessing how reliable an AI prediction is for a particular patient and setting.

Dr. Vivek pointed to the role of AI in automating several aspects of diagnosis and treatment. At the same time, he said, the technology remains a decision-support tool and cannot replace the dentist, who must continue to make the final clinical decision.

From a public health perspective, AI can act as a force multiplier in areas where specialist clinicians are scarce, said Mr. Gautham. He said it could make screening more accessible in rural and underserved settings and help prioritise patients requiring urgent attention, while accuracy, bias and clinical oversight remain important considerations.

The session was moderated by Geetha Srimathi, senior reporter, The Hindu and can be viewed at newsth.live/THSRMFY

Mobile phones, SIM cards, seized from terror convict's cell

Senjuti Sengupta
KOLKATA

Three mobile phones, Wi-Fi equipment, and ₹31,000 in cash were seized from the cell of Aftab Ahmed Ansari, the mastermind of the 2002 American Centre attack in Kolkata, who is serving a life term at the Presidency Correctional Home, officials said on Saturday.

Senior officials from the West Bengal correctional services said the items were seized during a surprise search operation at the Presidency jail on August 23, following intelligence inputs that Mr. Ansari was allegedly using a mobile phone and had internet access.

"Three smartphones, three SIM cards, two routers, a Wi-Fi hotspot device, a pen drive, an OTG adapter, and wireless earbuds are among the electronic communication dev-

ices seized by our staff," a senior officer said, adding that an investigation is underway to probe the potential involvement of jail staff.

The jail authority has lodged a case against Mr. Ansari at the Hastings police station. Investigators are also attempting to ascertain whether phone calls were made to Mr. Ansari's contacts outside the country.

American Centre attack

Mr. Ansari was a key member of the Dubai-based Asif Reza Commando Force, a wing of the Pakistan-based terrorist group Harkat-ul-Jehad-i-Islami. He was sentenced to life imprisonment in 2014 for the January 22, 2002, attack outside the American Centre in Kolkata, where two motorcycle-borne gunmen used AK-47 rifles to kill five police personnel and injure 20 others.

File FIR over Haldwani ritual, ensure justice for Kharge, Rahul tells Modi

Cong. leader frames the controversy as part of a larger conflict between constitutional values and BJP-RSS ideology, adding that untouchability is still a reality in India; he declines questions on Sonia’s memoir, terming them a ‘digression strategy’

Sandeep Phukan
NEW DELHI

Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi on Saturday mounted a sharp attack on the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) and Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) over the alleged *shuddhikaran* (purification) ceremony held at the venue of a rally addressed by Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge in Haldwani earlier in August. Mr. Gandhi said the act amounted to the practice of untouchability, which is a crime under the Constitution.

Hits out at BJP-RSS

Prime Minister Narendra Modi must ensure that a first information report (FIR) was registered against those responsible, Mr. Gandhi said, accusing the BJP-RSS of seeking to prevent Dalits from progressing and living with dignity and respect. “We are demanding justice for the Congress president. Give the Congress



Congress leader Rahul Gandhi addressing a press conference in New Delhi on Saturday. SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

president justice in Uttarakhand. It is the duty of the Central and State governments to ensure that Kharge *ji* gets justice,” Mr. Gandhi said at a press conference here. He declined to take questions on the controversy surrounding Penguin Random House India and the publication of Congress Parliamentary Party chairperson Sonia Gandhi’s memoir, *Belonging*, calling it a “digression strategy”. Penguin India reported-

ly dropped plans to publish the memoir after Ms. Gandhi refused to remove passages critical of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, the RSS, and China’s alleged occupation of Indian territory. “I don’t have any interest in this right now; I am interested in what they have done to Kharge *ji*,” Mr. Gandhi said. Nearly 20 days had passed since the alleged incident, but no action had been taken, he said. Referring to Uttarakhand BJP

president Mahendra Bhatt’s reported defence of the ceremony, Mr. Gandhi said the State BJP leadership had effectively justified an act of untouchability. “We demand that an FIR be lodged against those who have done this. PM Modi states that he belongs to every caste and is the Prime Minister of the country, but his party chief of Uttarakhand defends *shuddhikaran*,” he said.

Invokes Constitution

Opening his presentation with images of the Constitution and the *Manusmriti*, Mr. Gandhi framed the controversy as part of a larger ideological conflict between the constitutional values associated with B.R. Ambedkar, Mahatma Gandhi and Jawaharlal Nehru, and the ideology represented by the BJP-RSS. His invocation of the Constitution and the *Manusmriti* came amid the BJP’s recent attempt to portray him as “anti-Hindu”, accusing him of selec-

tively attacking Hindu religious texts while remaining silent on religious texts of other faiths during the Congress’s recent ‘*Chhatron ki Goonj*’ (echo of students) programme in Pune. Caste discrimination and untouchability continued to be a reality despite being prohibited by the Constitution, Mr. Gandhi said, citing instances of Dalit children allegedly being made to clean toilets in schools, discriminatory practices in public spaces, and violence against Dalit groom.

“The more successful the Dalit person is, the attack on him or her is more fierce,” he said, referring to similar alleged instances involving Mr. Kharge, Rajasthan Congress leader Tikaram Jully, and Union Minister Jitan Ram Manjhi. “This is another name for untouchability. The BJP people practice untouchability. When they do *shuddhikaran*, they say that Dalits cannot touch as they are impure,” Mr. Gandhi said.

Congress using Haldwani issue as opportunity to create social divisions: BJP

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) on Saturday cited testimonies of two Scheduled Caste eyewitnesses to claim that they exposed Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi’s narrative over an alleged incident in Haldwani, Uttarakhand, earlier this month.

The response came after Mr. Gandhi targeted the party, alleging that a “purification” ceremony was organised at a rally venue addressed by Congress chief Mallikarjun Kharge.

At a joint press conference, BJP leaders Guru Prakash Paswan and Sudhanshu Trivedi argued that a 20-day delay in raising the matter and seeking an FIR suggested that there was no genuine issue or legal basis. They said the matter was being used by the Congress as a “political opportunity” to further its politics of creating “social divisions”.

They played videos of two eyewitnesses, who are members of an organisa-



BJP leader Sudhanshu Trivedi said a 20-day delay in seeking an FIR suggested that issues raised were not genuine. @SUDHANSHUTRIVEDI/X

tion that cleaned the stage and organised a “*havan*” at the venue. The members of the organisation denied any caste angle to the “*havan*”. Referring to the eyewitnesses, Mr. Trivedi suggested that a counter-FIR could potentially be filed, without specifying against whom. Mr. Paswan described Mr. Gandhi and the Congress as “anti-Dalit” and “neo-feudal”. He said the party and its leaders had ill-treated Mr. Kharge, former Puducherry Chief Minister V. Narayanasamy, and senior Haryana Congress leader Kumari Selja, among others. “History is witness to

how Babasaheb Ambedkar and Babu Jagjivan Ram were treated. Babu Jagjivan Ram had to leave the Congress, and for the first time the country saw a person from the Dalit community become Deputy Prime Minister, in a government formed by the Bharatiya Jana Sangh,” Mr. Paswan said. “Today your government is in many States. How many SC, ST, and OBC Chief Ministers are there?” he asked, listing leaders from the Scheduled Tribe (ST) and Scheduled Caste (SC) communities who have held important positions under BJP-led governments.

Mamata faces FIR for ‘violating’ Calcutta HC order at party event

Shiv Sahay Singh
KOLKATA

The Kolkata Police have registered an FIR against former West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee, among others, for “violating” a Calcutta High Court order during a foundation day programme of the party’s student wing, Trinamool Congress Chhattra Parishad (TMCP), held on Cathedral Road in Kolkata. According to the police, the case was registered on Friday, under Sections 61 (2), 223, 125(a), 132 and 285 of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS). The case



Mamata Banerjee

was registered on the basis of a written complaint submitted by Sub-Inspector Apu Baidya of Hastings Police Station after examining the conditions imposed by the Calcutta High Court for holding the meeting at

Cathedral Road on Friday. A statement by the Kolkata Police accused the Trinamool Congress chairperson of entering into a criminal conspiracy by provoking her supporters during the programme, resulting in the crowd pushing aside the barricades and jostling with police personnel “deployed for maintaining law and order, creating a chaotic situation and obstructing the vehicular movement of one flank of Cathedral Road”. The Calcutta High Court has directed that the rally be held from 12 p.m. to 3 p.m. but the programme

went beyond the scheduled time. During the gathering, the Trinamool chairperson was heard repeatedly saying that she would finish the event by 3 p.m. The rally, however, went beyond 3 p.m. as she could not finish her speech in time. Trinamool Congress spokesperson and Belegata MLA Kunal Ghosh said that the FIR was politically motivated. “We tried to finish the rally in time. But if more people turn up it is the responsibility of the police to maintain the situation,” he said.

Those who ruled before BJP must explain caste discrimination: Chirag

Amarnath Tewary
PATNA

In response to Congress leader Rahul Gandhi’s recent remarks on caste discrimination, Union Minister of Food Processing Industries and Lok Janshakti Party (Ram Vilas) leader Chirag Paswan on Saturday demanded that those who were in power before the BJP regime should explain why discrimination against Dalits still persists in society. Meanwhile, he also demanded the resignation of Hindustani Awam Morcha (Secular) leader, Santosh



Chirag Paswan

Kumar Suman from the Bihar Cabinet after the party, an NDA ally, sought a review of the reservation policy and sub-categorisation of Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes. Mr. Paswan strongly de-

fended caste-based reservation, calling it an “unyielding constitutional right rather than charity”. While saying that reservation remains fully necessary because caste-based discrimination and social inequalities have not disappeared from modern society, Mr. Paswan asserted that “reservation, gifted by Dr. B.R. Ambedkar in the Constitution, cannot be abolished or undermined by any power on earth because groups or protesters demand it”. “If discrimination continued in society despite this, it implies that they (who ruled the coun-

try for long) too, failed to strengthen the foundations effectively”, he said. Mr. Suman responded to Mr. Paswan on Saturday in a post on social media platform X. “As far as the issue of my resignation, I’m ready for this, but my younger brother (Chirag Paswan) should start this by resigning first. My younger brother should understand better that I had never spoken about the creamy-layer, neither had I talked about ending reservation but of sub-categorisation in reservation regime and both should not be mixed...,” he said.

Nitin Nabin holds meet to discuss youth outreach plan

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) president Nitin Nabin on Saturday held a crucial meeting with party leaders to discuss and formulate the party’s youth outreach plan, sources said.

Poll preparedness

According to sources, the party’s preparations for the upcoming Assembly polls in seven States, including Uttar Pradesh, Punjab and Gujarat, was also a key agenda for the meeting. The meeting was attended by newly appointed BJP Yuva Morcha president Hemang Joshi. Former presidents of the party’s Yuva Morcha – Anurag Thakur, Poonam Mahajan and Tejasvi Surya – were also present at the meeting. Union Minister for Information and Broadcasting Ashwini Vaishnaw participated in the meeting, along with newly appointed BJP national general secretary Smriti Irani. Other attendees included Gujarat Deputy Chief Minister Harsh Sanghavi and Chhattisgarh Deputy Chief Minister Vijay Sharma.

Naveen urges Odisha BJP MPs to seek reversal of amendment to Mines and Minerals Act

Satvasundar Barik
BHUBANESWAR

Former Odisha Chief Minister and Biju Janata Dal (BJD) chief Naveen Patnaik on Saturday urged the State’s Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) MPs to challenge and call for a reversal of the Mines and Minerals (Development and Regulation) Amendment Act, 2026.

Odisha’s contributions “August 13, 2026, which saw the passage of the Mines and Minerals (Development and Regulation) Amendment Bill, 2026, in the Lok Sabha with your support, was a black day for Odisha. The Bill was passed with less than ten minutes of discussion in the Lok Sabha, despite having provisions with far-reaching implications for the people of the State,” Mr. Patnaik said in a letter addressed to BJP MPs. “This was not an ordinary piece of legislation. Odisha undoubtedly will be the worst affected by it. As you are well aware, Odisha accounts for nearly 44% of India’s mineral wealth. For decades, Odisha has con-



Naveen Patnaik

tributed its mineral wealth to the building of India’s steel, power, mining and infrastructure sectors,” he mentioned. “India stands taller and stronger today because of the immense contribution made by Odisha and her people. The estimated annual loss would be more than ₹12,000 crore, leading to lakhs of crores of rupees over time. But the bigger loss is that in a single legislative stroke, the control over our own minerals and mineral-bearing lands was taken away from us. And this happened under your watch,” Mr. Patnaik said.

Injustice to people “This law is an injustice to the children and youth of

Odisha whose future is linked to the resources and opportunities of this State. It is an injustice to the people of Odisha who bear the pollution, displacement, environmental degradation and the hazards and hardships of mining. And, above all, it is an injustice to the dream of an empowered Odisha that has the confidence and resources to determine its own future,” he said. Appealing to their conscience, Mr. Patnaik called on BJP MPs to advocate for the reversal of the MMDR Act amendment, citing its negative impact on Odisha’s future. “History remembers and honours those who raise their voice when injustice is done to their people and its resources. History will judge you not by the party you stood with, but by whether you stood up for Odisha when it mattered most. You are standing at a historic juncture with a choice to stand and fight for the State and the people who sent you to the Lok Sabha with a mandate to protect their interests,” said the five-time CM in the letter.

Jarange-Patil begins indefinite strike for Maratha quota; warns of march to Mumbai

The Hindu Bureau
MUMBAI

Maratha quota activist Manoj Jarange-Patil began an indefinite hunger strike at Antarwali Sarati in Jalna district on Saturday, reviving the reservation agitation and pressing the Maharashtra government to accept his demands, including the issuance of caste certificates based on the 58 lakh identified Kunbi records.

‘Issue caste certificates’ Addressing mediapersons at the protest site, Mr. Jarange-Patil said the government should not resort to delaying tactics. “Caste certificates and validity documents must be issued immediately based on the 58 lakh Kunbi records,” he said. “We will not give the government any additional time. This is the final battle. Every person should step out of their homes and participate in this fight,” he added. Mr. Jarange-Patil said the process of issuing Kunbi certificates to Marathas in Marathwada should be expedited based on the



Manoj Jarange-Patil had held a hunger strike in Sept. 2025, seeking the issuance of Kunbi caste certificates to eligible Marathas. FILE

Hyderabad Gazetteer.

He also called for the implementation of government resolutions (GRs) related to the Aundh-Pune, Bombay Government and Satara Gazetteers. “The government should not attempt to reduce the 58 lakh records identified by the Shinde committee or discard any of them. Certificates must be issued urgently on the basis of all these records,” he said. Mr. Jarange-Patil warned that if the demands were not accepted at Antarwali Sarati, the protest would be taken to Mumbai. “We will go to Varsha Bungalow or Azad Maidan,” he said, adding, “Mumbai residents should tolerate us. We are also

your people.” Among the activist’s fresh demands was the abolition of caste scrutiny committees in the State. “Caste scrutiny committees do not exist in other States. Why has this mechanism been kept only in Maharashtra? This information was given to me by Revenue Minister Radhakrishna Vikhe-Patil himself,” he said, suggesting that the process instead be simplified at the tehsildar level.

Police serve notice Meanwhile, Jalna district police served Mr. Jarange-Patil a notice under Section 168 of the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, to ensure law and order during the protest.

BJP rebukes three MPs for tribute to Sajjan Kumar

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The BJP leadership has expressed unhappiness over three of its Delhi MPs paying homage to the late Congress leader Sajjan Kumar, who was serving a jail term for his involvement in the 1984 anti-Sikh riots. BJP president Nitin Nabin summoned Kamaljeet Sehrawat, Ramvir Singh Bidhuri and Yogender Chandolia on Saturday and conveyed his displeasure, stating that the party does not approve of their visit to Mr. Kumar’s residence to offer condolences. Their visit became controversial after H.S. Phoolka, the lawyer for the riot victims, openly condemned it. Mr. Phoolka said on social media that the MPs visited Mr. Kumar’s house when the BJP had always supported the quest for justice for the victims. “Sympathy should be reserved for victims and their families – many of whom live the horror of those days till now,” he said, calling for a boycott of the three MPs. BJP’s national spokesperson R.P. Singh also condemned the MPs.

INBRIEF



Suspected Pak. drone triggers search operation along LoC

A drone suspected to be from Pakistan was spotted hovering over forward areas along the Line of Control (LoC) in Jammu and Kashmir's Poonch district, prompting security forces to launch a search operation in the area early Saturday, officials said. The drone was spotted in Balakote in the Mendhar sector late Friday evening, and it moved towards the Mangalnar-Dabrote side near the border before returning to Pakistan, the officials said. They said Army troops guarding the LoC intensified surveillance and launched a search operation at first light to determine whether it had dropped or carried any suspicious material. PTI

UGC-NET results announced; over 4,000 qualify for JRF

The results of the UGC National Eligibility Test (NET) for 84 subjects have been announced, with more than 4,000 candidates qualifying for the Junior Research Fellowship, the National Testing Agency has said. 6.07 lakh candidates took the exam, out of which over 97,000 have cleared it, a senior NTA official said on Friday. The examinations were conducted in June, with the NTA releasing the UGC-NET answer key on August 16. It also issued a special notice for re-examinations in Sociology, Commerce and English papers after an expert committee found factual, typographical, and language-related errors in the question papers. PTI

Bombay HC disposes PIL on language rule for drivers

The Bombay High Court on Saturday disposed of a public interest litigation (PIL) petition against a recent language rule after the Maharashtra government informed the court that auto-rickshaw, taxi and cab drivers in the State would be given one year to acquire a working knowledge of Marathi. A Division Bench of Acting Chief Justice Ravindra Ghuge and Justice Gautam Ankhad was hearing the PIL filed by four Uber drivers challenging the government's requirement that drivers possess a working knowledge of Marathi to obtain permits.

Court takes cognisance of NIA charges in Red Fort blast case

A special court on Saturday has taken cognisance of a chargesheet filed by NIA in connection with the explosion near Red Fort in New Delhi on November 10, 2025 which killed 14 people and injured dozens. According to the 7,500-page chargesheet, filed in May, the explosion was allegedly orchestrated by a terror module led by a group of doctors who had been searching for a suicide bomber for a year. Dr. Umar-un-Nabi, the prime accused, allegedly drove the explosives-laden vehicle that detonated near Red Fort. The NIA arrested 11 people accused of facilitating the attack by providing logistical support, sheltering suspects and attempting to destroy evidence.

SUDOKU

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DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★☆

Solution to yesterday's Sudoku

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3	9	7	1	6	5	2	4	8
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6	8	3	2	5	1	4	7	9
4	2	1	6	9	7	8	3	5
9	7	5	8	3	4	1	2	6
7	1	6	3	8	2	5	9	4
8	5	9	4	7	6	3	1	2
2	3	4	5	1	9	6	8	7

A quiet move that has kept Dehradun's vultures safe

Rahul Karmakar
GUWAHATI

Poisoning, veterinary non-steroidal anti-inflammatory drugs (NSAIDs), food scarcity, and habitat loss continue to remain survival challenges for vultures in India.

A decade-old study, published in the latest issue of the *Journal of Threatened Taxa*, suggests that relocating a livestock carcass dump 2.4 km away from high-tension power infrastructure near Uttarakhand's Dehradun may have saved these large scavengers from another existential threat – electrocution.

The authors of the study are Javed Anver, Yash Vardhan Singh Sengar, Bikash

Ghimire, Vonchano Ngulie, Hemam Rama Nanda, Tashi P. Dorji, Ankit Sharma, Akshay Jain, Sas Biswas, Arun Kumar, and M. Muzahed.

Vultures are among the most threatened birds globally, having undergone severe population declines across Asia and Africa due to multiple anthropogenic pressures. According to the study, electrocution from power infrastructure has been the most under-reported threat.

The study documented electrocution mortality of vultures in the Sudhauwala region of Dehradun, based on 34 surveys conducted between May 2011 and February 2014. The study recorded 743 individual vul-



Vultures are among the most threatened birds globally, having undergone severe population declines. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

tures belonging to five species.

“During the study period, 46 vulture carcasses attributable to electrocution were documented in proximity to high-tension

power transmission structures. The highest proportion of mortality relative to observations was recorded for the Himalayan griffon (*Gyps himalayensis*), followed by the Eurasian grif-

‘Irreverent Gen Z a sure sign of our democratic progress’

In a memorial lecture, former Chief Justice of Orissa HC says student protests give assurance that people will turn to the Constitution and safeguard it in order to preserve the country's future

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

As the coinage ‘dimagi Naxal’ continues to trigger political debate, former Chief Justice of Orissa High Court Justice S. Muralidhar has said it was reassuring to find that an irreverent young generation is neither swayed by rhetoric nor deterred by the “demonising” of the ‘dimagi Naxal’.

He said the very lack of deference among the Gen Z was a “sure sign of democratic progress”.

“The recent protests by our Gen Z assure us that democracy in India will not be allowed to die and that people will turn to the Constitution and safeguard it in order to preserve this country's future,” Justice Muralidhar said in his address at the 28th D.S. Borker Memorial Lecture on ‘My Vision of India 2047’ held



recently here.

“The India of 2047 would be better served if the law of today does not permit criminalising of honest criticism of a government or those running it, of their being lampooned in cartoons or joked about by stand-up comedians... if the government of the day stops weaponising law to punish those who peacefully protest

about the denial of basic rights and if it stops labelling them as sinister acts of conspiracy to destabilise the government,” Justice Muralidhar, currently practising as a senior advocate in the Supreme Court, said.

He said the judiciary of 2047 would be better served if “today's judges act swiftly on complaints of grave state excesses”.

‘FSSAI's proposed warning labels could let unhealthy foods escape scrutiny’

Bindu Shaian Perappadan
NEW DELHI

The Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI) has proposed red hexagonal warning labels on packaged foods high in sugar, salt, and saturated fat, but critical gaps in the framework could leave several unhealthy products with no warning, nutrition advocate Arun Gupta said. While the proposal marks a step forward after sustained intervention by the Supreme Court, its “two or more” nutrients threshold is a major loophole, Dr. Gupta, convener of Nutrition Advocacy in Public Interest (NAPI), told *The Hindu*.

The Supreme Court recently pushed the Centre and FSSAI to act swiftly on front-of-pack warning labels for unhealthy packaged foods. The FSSAI has now proposed red, hexagonal labels flagging products high in sugar, salt or fat to help consumers make informed choices.

Faulty framework

Under the proposal, a warning would be triggered only when a product is high in two or more nutrients of concern – added saturated fat, added sugar, and added salt. “A product



The top court recently pushed the Centre and the FSSAI to act swiftly on front-of-pack warning labels for packaged foods.

could be high in sugar but carry no warning if it is low in fat and salt. That defeats the purpose of a warning label,” Dr. Gupta said.

The rule, he said, should be simple: “High in sugar – warning; high in salt – warning; high in saturated fat – warning.” He also called for time-bound implementation, and said the framework should be aligned with the Indian Council of Medical Research-National Institute of Nutrition (ICMR-NIN) Dietary Guidelines, 2024, which provide thresholds for total sugar and total fat per 100 gm.

Dr. Gupta also questioned the proposed use of “added” nutrients and called for following a clear, scientifically robust definition of high fat, sugar and salt (HFSS) foods. “India already has an HFSS definition reflected in the 2022 draft notification and par-

liamentary discussions. We should not keep reinventing the definition in a way that weakens the regulation,” he said.

He also criticised the proposed size of the warning, which would be one point larger than the back-of-pack nutrition information. “If the nutrition table is printed in tiny type, making the warning one point larger does not make it prominent,” he said, calling for the size of the warning to be linked to the principal display area of the package.

India has mandatory nutrition information on packaged foods but has never had a mandatory front-of-pack warning specifically flagging products high in sugar, salt or saturated fat. FSSAI proposed HFSS and front-of-pack nutrition regulations in 2022, but the process has remained stalled.

House panel chief says didn't intend to question Modi govt.

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) MP Ganesh Singh, the chief of the Parliamentary Committee on Welfare of Other Backward Classes (OBCs), said on Saturday that his statement on the issue of the OBC creamy layer income test and equivalence of posts was “at no point intended to question the commitment of the government led by Hon'ble Prime Minister Narendra Modi towards the welfare and empowerment of the OBC community”.

The clarification came a day after he told *The Hindu* that the issue of establishing equivalence of posts and the equal application of the income test for OBC reservation appeared to be stuck between two Union ministries.

On Saturday, Mr. Singh said his intention was to “seek clarity and uniformity on the technical and administrative aspects” of the issue so that eligible candidates do not face “avoidable difficulties”. He said it was “not a comment on the government's commitment to OBC welfare”, and added that the “stalemate” between the two ministries had arisen because of a UPA-era letter that he claimed had obfuscated



BJP MP Ganesh Singh

the issue, referring to the 2004 clarificatory letter issued by the Department of Personnel and Training (DoPT).

This amid the recent furore over the Centre's submissions to the Supreme Court that it was finding it “extremely difficult” to implement the court's judgment settling the issue on March 11.

In March, the Supreme Court ruled that the DoPT was practising “hostile discrimination” in applying the income test differently to OBC candidates with parents in government service and those with parents in jobs where equivalence with government posts had not been established. It noted that for the latter, income from salaries was being included, while this was not the case for the former, and directed the government to create supernumerary posts for OBC candidates who were denied ‘non-creamy layer’ status based on this.

events recorded during limited post-relocation monitoring.

Other raptor species, including the black kite (*Milvus migrans*) and crested serpent eagle (*Spilornis cheela*), were also recorded at the relocated site.

“Our findings indicated that relocating carcass dumping sites away from hazardous power infrastructure can be a practical conservation measure for reducing electrocution risk and could potentially be applied in other affected areas,” Mr. Anver of the Dehradun-based Wildlife Institute of India told *The Hindu*.

However, no studies have been conducted after 2015.

NLUD students back NLSIU peers' right to convocation

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

In an extended multi-city chain of support, the Governing Council of the Student Bar Council of National Law University Delhi (NLUD) on Saturday expressed solidarity with the graduating students of the National Law School of India University (NLSIU), Bengaluru, appealing against the cancellation of their 34th annual convocation.

The NLSIU convocation was cancelled after graduating students objected to having Chief Justice of India Surya Kant and Bar Council of India (BCI) chairperson Manan Kumar Mishra at the event. The NLSIU students, in turn, were acting in solidarity with students at NALSAR, Hyderabad who had kicked off the original storm when they opposed the CJI's presence at their own convocation, in protest against his use of terms

like ‘cockroach’ and ‘parasites’ in the court room, as well as his initial response to police action against last month's student protests. The BCI had suddenly intervened with an aborted attempt to ban NALSAR students from professional enrolment. The NLSIU students had objected to the BCI's conduct, and sought an unconditional apology from Mr. Mishra.

On August 27, the NLSIU had informed graduating students that their degrees would be conferred in absentia after due approvals by governing bodies, and gave them the option of getting their certificates by courier or collecting them on campus.

The NLUD student body on Saturday urged the NLSIU administration to reconsider its decision and ensure that graduating students were afforded a fair opportunity to have their convocation conducted without compromising their right of expression.

Fish workers plan protest on livelihood concerns

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Fish workers who are part of the All India Fish Workers Federation will protest near Jantar Mantar here on Monday, urging the Union government to address their livelihood issues and provide them with health and accident insurance cover. They will also submit a memorandum to Union Fisheries Minister Rajiv Ranjan Singh, with a charter of demands, including control over multinational companies engaged in fishing.

The Union government must withdraw the “blue economy policy” as it subjugates the sea and the coast to multinational companies, the federation's leaders, R. Prasad, and Lok Sabha MP V. Selvaraj, said in a statement. They urged the Union government to provide land and houses to all fishing families.

The children of fish workers must get reservation and grants in higher education, and job reservation in the Indian Navy and Coast Guard, they said. Alleging that fish workers were tortured by foreign countries on the pretext of violating maritime boundaries, they demanded that the Centre must take steps to avoid such incidents.



Clearing the way: Rescue workers and heavy machinery clear mud and debris in a flood-hit area of Nepal, after a devastating flash flood swept through villages in the northern part of the country.



Temporary refuge: A woman feeds a child at a relief camp in Nuwakot. Nepal's disaster authority said 4,451 people had been rescued so far and search operations are still on.



A trail of ruin: The remains of homes and other buildings are seen buried under mud and debris in a flood-hit area of Nepal.

Hope hangs in the skies



Prabhat Khanal

Rescue teams in Nepal's Nuwakot district are searching for people feared trapped in a blocked hydropower tunnel in Rasuwa, while families at relief camps wait anxiously for helicopters carrying their loved ones

In August 26, a catastrophic flash flood triggered by a high-altitude glacial collapse along the Nepal-Tibet border decimated the Bhotekoshi and Trishuli river corridors. The disaster heavily impacted multiple regions, completely devastating the Trishuli River basin and Bidur Municipality in Nuwakot district with extreme torrents and sudden landslides. Those rescued are constantly scanning the skies for helicopters, hoping they are bringing back family members who remain stranded in villages upstream. As floodwaters from the Bhotekoshi flowed into the Trishuli River, the sudden surge triggered landslides and widespread destruction downstream in Bidur Municipality and across Nuwakot district. The Nepal Army and Armed Police Force are trying to clear a blocked tunnel at a hydropower project in Rasuwa district, hoping to find people who may be trapped inside.



Emergency care: Nepali Army doctors treat a woman at a field hospital in Battar, Nuwakot, after she was rescued from the Bhotekoshi flood.



Into the field: Nepali Army rescue personnel head towards an airstrip near Nuwakot as teams remain on alert for further flooding after a debris dam burst on August 28.

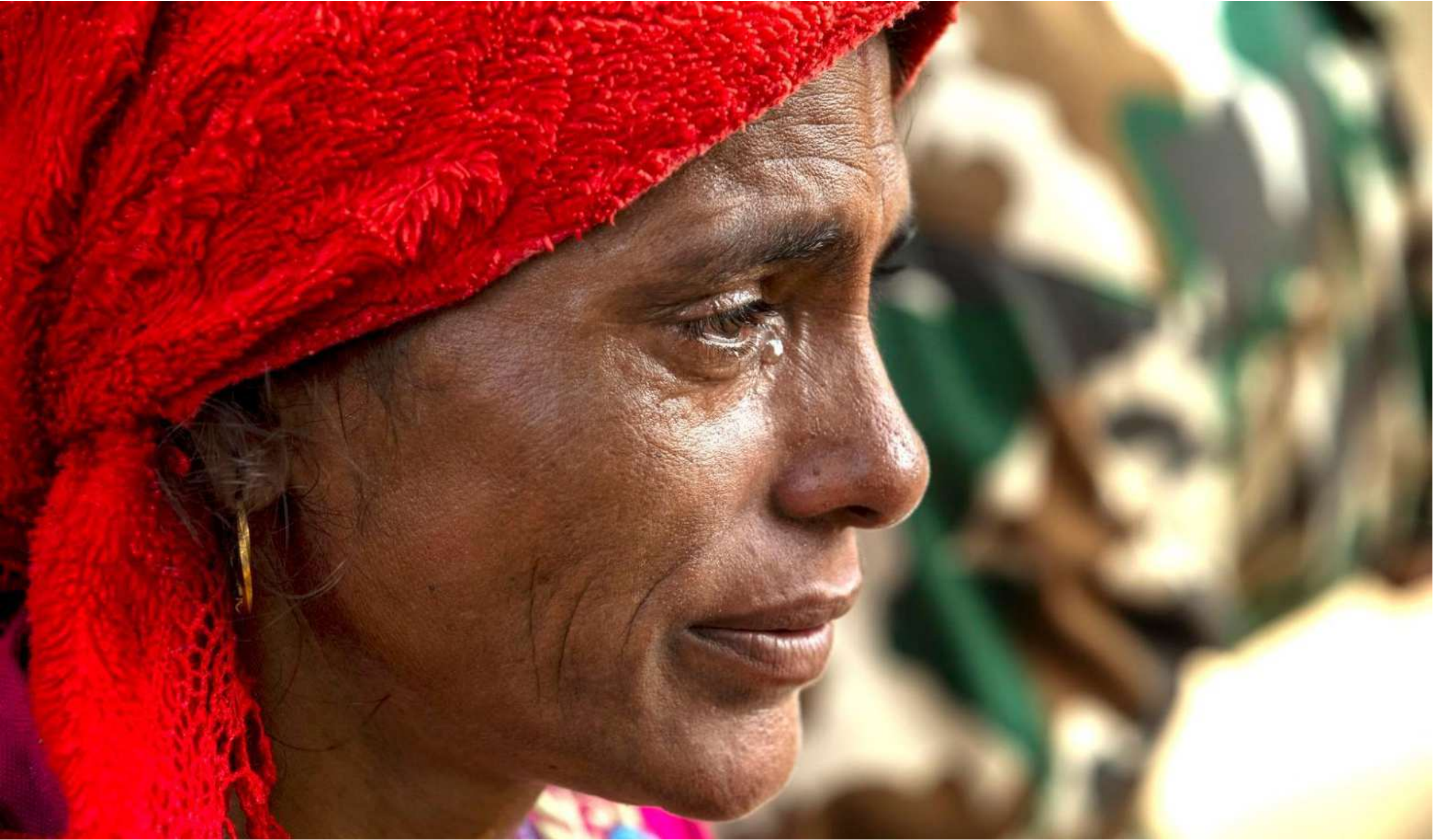


A long wait: Relatives search lists of missing people outside a hospital in Battar, Nuwakot, on August 28; at least 2,426 people remain missing.



Rescue under way: A helicopter flies rescue missions in Rasuwa district of Nepal where many people have been stranded.

Seeking answers: Relatives give the names of missing family members to officials as the search for survivors continues; among those out of contact are hundreds of foreign nationals.



Tears of relief: A woman becomes emotional at a Nepali Army camp in Nuwakot after being rescued, as her injured husband is taken to Kathmandu for treatment. Her family, originally from western Nepal, ran a hotel in Rasuwa.

PROFILES

A Himalayan tragedy

The Bhotekoshi flood

Scientists investigate how a high-altitude rock-and-ice avalanche may have triggered one of Nepal's most devastating floods; while experts have not directly attributed this event to climate change, they note that rising temperatures are warming the Himalayas and accelerating glacier melt

Sanjeev Satgainya

Ramesh Kumar, a journalist based in Kathmandu, on Thursday posted a photograph of a clock tower, its hands stopped at 09.29.

“A clock that would never show the time again,” he wrote on X, formerly Twitter. “Betrawati.”

Mr. Kumar had reached Betrawati in Nuwakot district, a town devastated by the previous day’s flood in the Bhotekoshi River in neighbouring Rasuwa district, which borders Tibet. After touring Betrawati, where he was born and raised, he made a grim assessment: “Will Betrawati ever revive as a bazaar again? Almost impossible.”

The extraordinary velocity and scale of the flash flood in the Bhotekoshi River at around 8.40 a.m. on Wednesday has left more than 600 dead and close to 2,500 missing, including foreign nationals, mostly from India.

The Nepal government promptly got into action, mobilising personnel from the Nepal Army, Nepal Police and the Armed Police Force, as it mounted a massive search-and-rescue operation.

Scientists, meanwhile, struggled to piece together the chain of events and determine the origin of the flood, as they wondered about the enormity of the disaster, with some describing it as the worst since the 2015 earthquake.

On the origin, the Nepalese and Chinese sides have concluded that the source was in the Langtang Lirung area. Identifying the exact point where the initial collapse occurred, and which side of the border it was on, may be difficult.

According to an official at Nepal’s Department of Hydrology and Meteorology, satellite imagery shared by the Chinese side pointed to a combination of an ice avalanche, permafrost movement and a rockslide along the Nepal-China border, with the rockslide occurring on the Chinese side and its impact extending into Nepal.

“The avalanche originated on the Nepalese side of the territory, but very close to the boundary, and induced



AFF

flooding that crossed the Nepal-China border, causing extensive damage on both sides,” said Binod Parajuli, a senior divisional hydrologist at the department’s flood forecasting division.

The location scientists are pointing to is in the Lhende Khola, a transboundary high-altitude river that originates in Gyirong County in Tibet and flows south into Nepal, where it is a tributary of the Bhotekoshi and Trishuli river systems.

Flooding in the Bhotekoshi River is not uncommon. Last year, in July, a flood – caused without rainfall – in the Bhotekoshi wreaked damage and destruction. Scientists later concluded that the disaster was associated with a glacial lake outburst flood (GLOF).

Different angle

While scientists initially considered whether this year’s flood could also have been linked to a GLOF, its velocity and ferocity, which washed away villages downstream in three districts – Rasuwa, Nuwakot and Dhading – prompted experts to examine it from a different angle.

Dr. Ranjan Kumar Dahal, an associate professor at the Himalayan Geodisaster Research Centre at the Central Department of Geology, Tribhuvan University, described the mass movement that triggered the flood as a sturzstrom.

“A sturzstrom is a massive rock avalanche in which a large volume of rock suddenly collapses and moves at extremely high speed over a long distance,” Mr. Dahal told *The Hindu* from Trishuli, another area hit hard by Wednesday’s flood. “In high-mountain environments, when rock is mixed with ice, snow, firn and frozen soil, it can be understood as a rock-ice avalanche.”

Rasuwagadhi in Rasuwa is a border checkpoint through which most of Nepal’s trade with China takes place. From May to September, hundreds of pilgrims use this border point to cross into Tibet for the Kailash Mansarovar pilgrimage. Indians make up the largest share of the pilgrims.

It could take weeks, if not months, to assess the full scale of the damage, officials said, adding that the toll could further rise.

The International Federation of Red Cross said the remoteness of the affected areas, combined with damaged infrastructure, was making it harder both to assess the full scale of the disaster and to deliver assistance to people who need it.

“Current estimates suggest around 93,000 people may have been affected,” it said. “Many homes have been severely damaged, cutting off some of the worst-affected communities.”

In the aftermath of the disaster, two more crucial questions have also emerged – whether the early-warning systems were activated and whether climate change had a role in the disaster. Experts say early-warning systems had worked as intended but were rendered ineffective given the staggering speed of the flood.

Kamal Kishore, the head of the UN Office for Disaster Risk Reduction, said the floods had once again highlighted how fragile mountain ecosystems are and how challenging it is to set up early-warning systems in mountain environments.

Scientists have not ruled out the

impact of climate change, saying the rising temperatures are causing the Himalayas to warm and glaciers to melt faster, but they stopped short of directly linking the disaster to global warming.

“We had not seen such a disaster in Nepal involving a sturzstrom. However, in 2021, there was a similar event in India,” said Mr. Dahal, referring to the Chamoli disaster in Uttarakhand, where a bedrock failure beneath a glacier triggered a massive rock-ice avalanche that subsequently transformed into a debris flow and flood.

The 2021 Chamoli event has been scientifically described as a rock-and-ice avalanche and, in some literature, explicitly as a sturzstrom. Research found that more than 25 million cubic metres of rock and ice broke loose high in the Uttarakhand Himalaya before moving rapidly downstream.

Catastrophic sturzstrom

“A sturzstrom begins when an unstable rock-ice slope suddenly collapses. The collapsing mass rapidly accelerates, fragments and mixes with ice and snow,” Mr. Dahal explained.

“Pressure and friction can generate meltwater, which may increase lubrication within the moving mass and along its base, reducing resistance and contributing to exceptionally long runoff,” he added.

According to him, this process can unfold within just a few minutes.

“As it moves downslope, it may incorporate more ice, snow, rock, soil and water, potentially transforming into a massive debris flow before finally depositing its material,” he said.

Meanwhile, rescue operations have continued on the fourth day, with Prime Minister Balendra Shah saying more than 15,000 personnel have been deployed.

For communities along the Bhotekoshi-Trishuli corridor, the immediate priorities are finding the missing, restoring access and assessing whether some of the places destroyed by the flood can be rebuilt at all.

It’s a race against time.

THE GIST

- ▼ The flood devastated riverside towns across Rasuwa, Nuwakot and Dhading districts, burying places like Betrawati and Trishuli under metres of mud, boulders and silt
- ▼ Nepal mobilised a massive search-and-rescue operation involving personnel from the Army, police and armed police force
- ▼ The remoteness of affected areas and damaged access routes have severely hampered both damage assessment and delivery of aid

Trump’s crypto U-turn

World Liberty Financial

Investments from a top UAE official into U.S. President’s crypto enterprise attract criticisms of conflict of interest and foreign influence

Nivedita Varadarajan

U.S. President Donald Trump has built a business empire spanning real estate, casinos and entertainment. His family’s growing crypto dealings are now facing mounting criticism over conflicts of interest and foreign influence.

A top United Arab Emirates official holds a stake in the family’s latest venture: a planned crypto bank now drawing scrutiny over foreign ties to a sitting President. The *Wall Street Journal* has reported that Sheikh Tahnoon bin Zayed al Nahyan, the UAE’s national security adviser, and his co-investors own a major stake in the company behind that bank.

Earlier this month, Office of the Comptroller of the Currency gave conditional approval to World Liberty Financial, backed by Mr. Trump’s family and close allies, to set up a federally chartered U.S. trust bank to issue, redeem and safeguard a dollar-backed stablecoin, USD1.

Mr. Tahnoon and his co-investors own 49% stake in bank’s holding company, the *Journal* reported. “The shareholder structure of the bank’s holding company, called WLTC Holdings, is the same as World Liberty’s, though Tahnoon and his co-investors used a different entity – called StringZ Holding RSC – for the stake in WLTC. An enti-



REUTERS

ty affiliated with the Trump family holds a 38% stake,” the *Journal* said, quoting a source.

Mr. Tahnoon and others had invested \$500 million in World Liberty Financial in January 2025. “The deal, signed four days before President Trump’s inauguration, steered \$263 million to Trump family entities, according to the President’s most recent financial disclosure,” the *Journal* noted.

A stablecoin is designed to maintain a stable value and reduce volatility. It is pegged to a currency, commodity or other asset, which may be held in reserve to back its value.

“USD1 now has a market value of \$4 billion. World Liberty says the dollars backing USD1 are invested in U.S. Treasury and other cash equivalents, generating an estimated \$150 million a year in interest,” the *Journal* reported.

Mr. Trump was not always fond of cryptocurrencies. During his first term, he bashed Facebook’s plans to create a digital cur-

rency. He dismissed Bitcoin and its peers as “not money,” calling their value “highly volatile and based on thin air”. In 2021, he told *Fox Business* that Bitcoin was a “scam”. “I think they should regulate them very, very high,” he said, adding, “It takes the edge off of the dollar and the importance of the dollar.”

Policy shift

That changed as the 2024 election approached. Crypto companies funnelled more than \$119 million into a non-partisan super PAC to elect pro-crypto candidates in that cycle, and Mr. Trump vowed to make the United States the “crypto capital of the planet”.

In March 2025, Mr. Trump created the U.S. Strategic Bitcoin Reserve by executive order, treating Bitcoin as a long-term reserve asset on par with gold. That July, he signed the GENIUS (Guiding and Establishing National Innovation for U.S. Stablecoins) Act, laying out regulatory guidelines for stablecoins.

Financial disclosures filed in June show he earned more than \$1.4 billion from his crypto ventures. Over \$500 million of it from World Liberty Financial, and another \$635 million from sales of his \$TRUMP meme coin. His reported income for the year was over \$2.2 billion, much higher than his 2024 income of \$600 million.

Founded in 2024, World Liberty Financial is at the heart of the Trump’s crypto empire. Its CEO Zach Witkoff, is the son of Mr. Trump’s West Asia envoy, Steve Witkoff. Other co-founders include Donald Trump Jr., Eric Trump, Barron Trump, Steve Witkoff, and the President himself. This arrangement could blur the line that separates governance and private financial interests. The Trump administration sets policy, and the President’s family and allies benefit financially.

Mr. Tahnoon’s investment is especially notable given the UAE’s position as a key U.S. partner in West Asia. Since the beginning of the U.S.-Israeli strikes on Iran on February 28, Gulf countries have borne a significant share of Iran’s retaliatory attacks, with the war also disrupting maritime traffic in the region.

These relationships raise fundamental questions: Can a sitting President accept investments from a foreign government official in his companies?

Smriti Sudesh

“We are taking the first step on a thousand-kilometre road. We are taking a step towards democracy for everyone,” Abdullah Ocalan said in early August.

The remarks by the Kurdistan Workers’ Party (PKK) leader, who has been in prison since 1999, came at an important moment as Türkiye attempts to end its long-running conflict with Kurdish minority militants.

The latest development came on August 24, when a Monitoring and Evaluation Board set up to oversee the process held its first meeting. The Board, chaired by Vice-President Cevdet Yilmaz, brought together senior officials including Foreign Minister Hakan Fidan, Defence Minister Yasar Guler and National Intelligence Organisation chief Ibrahim Kalin. It decided to set up four working groups dealing with legal issues, disarmament, monitoring, and the social reintegration of former militants.

The move is significant because the process is now moving beyond declarations. Several attempts to bring peace in the past remained unsuccessful; most recently in 2015.

A new law passed by Parliament on August 10, as part of that effort, was approved by 468 of the 592



REUTERS

lawmakers who voted.

The law provides conditional amnesty measures for people accused or convicted of offences linked to the PKK, including membership, assisting the organisation, spreading propaganda, and financing terrorism. It could pave the way for thousands of militants to return to Türkiye and reintegrate into society. The government, meanwhile, has stressed that it is not a general amnesty.

For those covered by the law, prison sentences can be suspended and ongoing investigations and trials can be put on hold for five to 10 years. If no terrorism-related offences are committed during that period, the suspended sentences would be considered served and pending cases would be dropped.

There are clear limits, however. Those convicted of intentional killings are excluded. So are people sentenced to life imprisonment without parole for offences committed before 2005. That is particularly significant for Mr. Ocalan.

Despite being a central figure in the current peace process, he would not benefit from the new law. Mr. Yilmaz said Mr. Ocalan’s case “does not fall within the scope of this law”, but added that he could remain “in a position to contribute to the peace process”.

The PKK has called the legislation a “beginning” but said it contains “serious shortcomings and deficiencies”. It has also demanded Mr. Ocalan’s release, stating that the process can move forward only if he “lives and works freely”.

A long conflict

The PKK began its armed insurgency against the Turkish state in 1984, seeking self-rule for Kurds inside Türkiye. Over the next four decades, the conflict killed more than 40,000 people, devastated parts of south-eastern Türkiye and became one of the defining issues of Turkish politics. The PKK is designated as a terrorist organisation by Türkiye, the United States

and the European Union.

The current attempt at a settlement began taking shape in 2024, when Ankara opened a new channel of dialogue with the Kurdish movement.

Later in February 2025, Mr. Ocalan called on the PKK to lay down its arms and dissolve. The group announced its dissolution in May, formally ending its armed campaign. In July, the disarmament process began with a symbolic ceremony in northern Iraq, where PKK burned their weapons. Since then, Ankara has been building the legal and institutional framework around what the government calls “Terror-Free Türkiye”.

His February call made him an important channel of communication between the organisation and Ankara. The DEM Party, Türkiye’s main Kurdish political movement, has also helped facilitate communication between Mr. Ocalan and the government.

The immediate challenge now is to see how the law will come into force. The measures will take effect only after Türkiye’s National Security Council – chaired by President Recep Tayyip Erdogan – confirms that the PKK has dissolved and surrendered its weapons. The Council is expected to consider findings from Turkish security institutions at its October meeting.

LOOKING AT POSITIVES

Collective effort is going to take the players a long way: Prasidh



PTI

The ones who played [against Sri Lanka] obviously got the credit that they were due. But all the reserves out there... running in and helping all of us. This effort is going to take us all a long way. This is the way the team has to be run — India pacer Prasidh Krishna to his teammates after the Test series.

ARCHER'S ARROW

'It's nice having extra seamers in the team, I could play until I'm 40'



AP

Jofra Archer said he might play till he turns 40, thanks to the benefits of being a member of England's pace quartet. Archer, Robinson, Tongue and Atkinson have all featured in the side in the series against Pakistan. "It's nice having the extra seamers in the line-up. I could play until I'm 40 at this rate," said the 31-year-old.

MIXED BAG

South Africa loses to Namibia, but bounces back against Zimbabwe



SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

South Africa suffered an 18-run defeat against host Namibia in the opening match of the tri-series at Windhoek on Friday. However, the Proteas beat Zimbabwe on Saturday. **The scores: Saturday:** Zimbabwe 144/8 in 20 overs lost to South Africa 146/3 in 13.4 overs; **Friday:** Namibia 163/9 in 20 overs bt South Africa 145/9 in 20 overs.

RIGHT CHOICE

Mourinho feels Mbappe should be given the Ballon d'Or this year



REUTERS

Real Madrid coach Jose Mourinho said Kylian Mbappe deserves to win this year's Ballon d'Or, arguing that the award should go to "the best player in the world" rather than be decided by World Cup or Champions League success. "For me, there is one who made history this summer," said Mourinho, referring to Mbappe.



On top of the world: Argentina scored a late equaliser and went on to prevail in penalties. AP

Argentina breaks Dutch hearts in a shootout

Granatto finds the equaliser for the South Americans in the 53rd minute after Jansen opens the scoring for Netherlands; Cosentino saves two penalties before Cairo's goal seals the deal

HOCKEY WORLD CUP

Aashin Prasad
AMSTELVEEN

On a chilly summer evening at the Wagener Stadion, Argentina's women had their own Maracanazo moment. Netherlands does not lose often. In the last 13 years, it has lost just one game a year while lifting three successive World Cups. On Saturday, too, Netherlands was on the verge of winning before Argentina struck late to hold it to a 1-1

draw. The Argentines went on to dethrone the Dutch in a penalty shootout. After Cristina Cosentino saved two Netherlands penalties, Sofia Cairo made it 3-1 when she put the ball in the net and sparked celebrations in the Argentina camp. It was doubly sweet for the South American nation as it avenged its 2022 final loss while also silencing a partisan home crowd at one of the cathedrals of the sport. In a highly anticipated rematch, both teams struggled to impose themselves

in open play as they looked overawed by the occasion. It was left to the talismanic dragflickers to have their say in penalty corners. It needed 30 minutes for the first one to arrive. Yibbi Jansen didn't even need a sighter and the tournament's top-scorer sounded the boards to hoist the lead for the host. In response, Argentina's penalty corner set-up squandered four chances in the third quarter. But, the South Americans continued to push on through Cairo, whose snaking runs into the circle

troubled the home side's defence and earned many penalty corners. With seven minutes to go, Argentina opted for a variation. Agustina Gorzelany fired her dragpush into the path of a teammate, who deflected the ball to an unmarked Maria Granatto for the equaliser. In the third-place play-off, co-host Belgium beat Australia 1-0 through a goal from Charlotte Engelbert. **The result (final):** Netherlands 1 (Yibbi Jansen 30-pc) drew with Argentina 1 (Maria Granatto 53-pc). Argentina won 3-1 on penalties.

The siblings are having a grand year on chess tour

P.K. Ajith Kumar

They are the world's first brother-sister Grandmaster duo. And this is turning out to be their grandest year on the chessboard. R. Praggnanandhaa and R. Vaishali have already recorded some of their finest performances this year. How Vaishali won the Candidates tournament after starting out as the eight seed in a field of eight in Cyprus in April has been the biggest story of the year in women's chess so far.

She became the first Indian woman to win the Candidates and will now play China's Ju Wenjun for the World championship. Koneru Humpy is the only Indian to have contested the Women's World championship. After her greatest moment, Vaishali had told this correspondent over the phone from Cyprus how helpful the presence of her younger brother was at the Candidates tournament. Personally for Praggnanandhaa, it was a tournament to forget, though: in the open event he finished seventh. But the gritty fighter that he is, he has battled



Family affair: Pragg and Vaishali will be part of India's challenge at the Olympiad in Samarkand. FILE PHOTO

his way back to top form since. During the last three months, he has won as many major titles — Norway Chess, where he stunned the World No. 1 Magnus Carlsen twice, the Saint Louis Rapid & Blitz and then the Grand Chess Tour, in the finals of which he outwitted the World No. 2 Fabiano Caruana just a couple of days ago at St. Louis. Vaishali was also in the American city alongside Praggnanandhaa, but she

didn't have a great time, though. She was there for the Cairns Cup. They would soon be travelling together for a much bigger event. The Chess Olympiad, to be held at Samarkand next month, will see them representing India. And they could have key roles to play in India's title defence. At the last Olympiad in Budapest in 2024, India was crowned champion in both the open and women's sections.

England pulls away further at Lord's

Associated Press
LONDON

England extended its lead over Pakistan in the second Test to 357 runs after reaching 177 for seven at the end of a rain-hit third day at Lord's, where only 24.5 overs were possible. There was no action on Saturday morning at the Home of Cricket because of showers.

Quickfire

The host eventually resumed at 81 for three in the afternoon, and Dan Lawrence raced to his half-century by the time more rain arrived in the third session. The teams never got back on the field again, with play eventually abandoned for the day at 6.30 p.m. local time due to bad light. England lost four wickets — Emilio Gay, Harry Brook and Jamie Smith in the second period, all to Mohammad Abbas (three for 48), and Gus Atkinson to Mohammad Ali — while adding 96 runs. Lawrence and Ollie Robinson (2) were in the middle at close. **The scores:** England 290 & 177/7 in 46.5 overs (Lawrence 50 batting, Abbas 3/48) vs. Pakistan 110.

Semifinals promise much as Central battles East and South spars with North

DULEEP TROPHY

N. Sudarshan
BENGALURU

The cream of Indian cricket's second rung will be in action as the 2026-27 Duleep Trophy semifinal fixtures get underway at the BCCI Centre of Excellence from Sunday. Defending champion Central Zone will take on East while last season's finalist South Zone will spar with North. East and North notched up contrasting victories in the quarterfinals. Where East, marshalled by Ishan Kishan, recorded a thumping innings and 210-run win over North East, Kanhaiya Wadhawan's North conjured a dramatic 52-run success despite West Zone coasting at 195 for three while chasing 287. Teenage sensation Vaibhav Sooryavanshi could only score eight runs for East but picked up two wickets with his left-arm spin in the second essay. The last-four clash will offer him another opportunity at bettering his middling First Class numbers (215 runs from 13 innings at average of 16.53). Keeping him silent will be high on Central skipper



Key players: While Vaibhav, who has picked up wickets, will look to better his batting record, Abid will aim to carry on his good form with the ball. K. MURALI KUMAR, ALLEN EGENUSE J.



Rajat Patidar's priorities, and it remains to be seen if off-spinner Saransh Jain can aid him in this. Saransh is part of the roster but made his India debut in the second Test against Sri Lanka in Colombo, which kept him on the field until Thursday. But fellow India international Gurnoor Brar — who didn't play either Test in Sri Lanka — has been added to the North Zone squad and participated in Saturday morning's practice. His entry further bolsters North's pace attack, for it already has Anshul Kamboj and Arshdeep Singh.

Jammu & Kashmir left-arm spinner Abid Mushtaq starred in the win over West with a match-haul of nine for 99. Whether he gets the same purchase at CoE Ground 2 as he did on the red-soil wicket at Ground 1 will be intriguing to watch. South has a solid batting line-up, led by skipper Tilak Varma, R. Smaran — 2025-26 Ranji Trophy's leading scorer with 950 runs — and Karun Nair. There is also Shaik Rashed, the highly rated 21-year-old, who made 627 runs in Andhra's dash to the Ranji quarterfinals last season.

My best in terms of quality and consistency: Velavan

SQUASH

K. Keerthivasan
CHENNAI

Sparring with World No. 15 Mohamed ElShorbagy and World No. 22 Baptiste Mastti under the watchful eyes of French coach Gregory Gaultier in Prague over the last few weeks has made India's Velavan Senthilkumar a more solid and consistent player. The 28-year-old's preparation ahead of the new season paid handsome dividends as he clinched his maiden PSA World Tour title at the Budapest Open on Friday. In the Copper event, the World No. 54 defeated Hungary's Balazs Farkas 11-4, 11-2, 11-3 in the final to bag his 11th PSA crown. On winning the biggest trophy of his career yet, Velavan said: "This is the best I've played in terms of the quality of squash and the consistency I displayed." Working with Gaultier, a former World No. 1, and Saurav Ghosal helped him immensely. "With Gaultier, I am putting in the hard yards and with Saurav, I am working on a few technical aspects," he said. Beating top seed Eain Yow Ng of Malaysia for the first time — in the last-eight stage — was a huge confidence



First of many? Velavan won his maiden PSA World Tour title on Friday. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



Joshna is the most experienced player in the Indian team. She knows all the subtleties of doubles. I am trying to learn from her down 8-10 in the fifth game. Eventually winning it 12-10 was a really good indicator [of how I played]," he said. His ultimate goal is to break into the world's top 20 by the end of the season. Excited The southpaw is excited to play with Joshna Chinappa in mixed doubles at the Asian Games. "She is the most experienced player in the Indian team. She knows all the subtleties of doubles. I am trying to learn all of that from her," said Velavan, who had won bronze with Joshna at the Asian Doubles Championships in June.

Man City overruns Palace, Liverpool held

EURO LEAGUES

Agence France-Presse
LONDON

Rayan Cherki proved his point to Enzo Maresca as the Manchester City star's brilliant double inspired a 4-1 rout of Crystal Palace on Friday. Cherki scored a brace after an own goal from City keeper Gianluigi Donnarumma had cancelled out Erling Haaland's opener in rainy south London. Haaland struck again in the closing stages to cap City's dominant display. In Saturday's early kickoff, Andoni Iraola escaped defeat on his Anfield debut as Liverpool manager thanks to Victor Munoz's strike to salvage a 2-2 draw against Nottingham Forest. Michael Olise and Luis Diaz were among five different scorers as Bayern Munich cruised to a 5-1 win

over Stuttgart in Friday's Bundesliga opener. **The results:** **Premier League:** Liverpool 2 (Isak 60, Munoz 82) drew with Nottingham Forest 2 (Ndoye 24, Gibbs-White 70-pen); Bournemouth 1 (Scott 41) drew with Everton 1 (Tarkowski 90+1); Coventry 0 lost to Hull 1 (Millar 82); Tottenham 0 lost to Newcastle 2 (Elanga 62, Wissa 72). **LaLiga:** Levante 5 (De La Fuente 24, Bardeli 45+2, Brugue 56, 70, Olasagasti 90+5) bt Real Betis 2 (Bartra 34, Riquelme 45+4). **Bundesliga:** RB Leipzig 3 (Baku 25, Nusa 49, Reitz 66) bt Borussia M'Gladbach 0; Mainz 0 drew with Paderborn 0; Union Berlin 3 (Llatte Lath 3, Querfeld 79, Skarke 90+2) drew with Eintracht Frankfurt 3 (Ebounatlib 10, 11, 67); Elversberg 3 (Petkov 8, Campbell 9, Mokwa 46) bt Bayer Leverkusen 2 (Schick 77, Kofane 90+1). **On Friday: Premier League:** Crystal Palace 1 (Donnarumma 56-og) lost to Manchester City 4 (Haaland 17, 84, Cherki 54, 59). **Serie A:** AC Milan 2 (Ramos 69, Halhal 89-og) bt Venezia 0.



The stars: Goal-scorers Haaland and Cherki celebrate. AP

A IN-X

KARNATAKA



Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar at the foundation stone-laying ceremony for the three-lane twin tunnel connecting Hebbal flyover area to UAS staff quarters through KVAFSU campus in Bengaluru. FILE PHOTO



The ongoing Blue Line metro work on the Outer Ring Road in Bellandur. ALLEN EGENUSE J.



Land notified for acquisition for the township project at Bidadi. ALLEN EGENUSE J.



Soil testing under way for the tunnel project near Hebbal. SUDHAKARA JAIN

Big-ticket infra projects or white elephants?

The State government is pushing for projects worth nearly ₹1.5 lakh crore in and around Bengaluru, which activists argue are ‘vanity projects’ being built exclusively for cars. Are they worth being tolled or is it a case of the poor subsidising the rich? **Chetan B.C. and K.V. Aditya Bharadwaj** explore...

After a two-decade lull, barring the slow-moving Namma Metro, the Karnataka government is now pushing for several big ticket infrastructure projects in and around Bengaluru worth nearly ₹1.5 lakh crore.

Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar has been talking of building “New Bengalurus” on the back of these big ticket infra-projects. These include two twin-tunnel roads and 13 elevated corridors criss-crossing the city, Peripheral Ring Road (PRR) around the city, and Live-Work-Play townships in Bidadi and near Doddaballapur.

Almost all the projects are facing opposition either from land owners resisting acquisition of their land or by civic activists arguing these are “white elephants” and “vanity projects” being built exclusively for cars. There are multiple petitions challenging the tunnel road project in the High Court of Karnataka and the National Green Tribunal on various grounds, including statutory non-compliance, damage to the environment, etc.



Ground survey under way on SJP Road for the proposed Twin Tunnel Road project linking Hebbal and Central Silk Board. K. MURALI KUMAR

But what has gone below the radar is how most of these road projects will be heavily tolled. The two twin-tunnel projects, four long flyovers cutting across the city, and the PRR will be tolled, making the commute expensive and exclusive for those who can afford it.

On the other hand, the State is not investing directly in these projects. Special Purpose Vehicles (SPVs) like Bengaluru Business Corridor Ltd. and Bengaluru Smart Infrastructure Ltd. (B-SMILE) set up by the State have raised huge loans to fund them and the State has only given sovereign guarantee. Barring PRR-funded entirely through a Housing and Urban Development Corporation Ltd. (HUDCO) loan of ₹27,000 crore, the rest of the projects have private investments, but not fully. These SPVs have again raised loans to give Viability Gap Funding of 40% for twin-tunnels and two flyovers, while the other two will be built entirely by private players.

Activists argue that this means that public money is being pumped in to build infrastructure solely for the rich.

Exorbitant toll

While the toll structure for the rest of the projects is not in the public domain yet, the estimated toll in the 16.7 km long North-South Twin-Tunnel Road between Hebbal and Silk Board is pegged at ₹19 per km in the Detailed Project Report (DPR). This means a one-way trip will cost ₹317, and nearly ₹650 for a round trip. Only cars and buses are likely to be allowed.

This toll structure, part of the DPR, is for the project estimated to cost ₹17,700 crore, which according to B.S. Prahallad, technical director, B-SMILE, may go up to ₹20,000 crore with the inclusion of utilities and other factors. However, Adani Enterprises Ltd., which has emerged as the lowest bidder, has quoted over ₹22,000 crore for the project, which is still under evaluation.

This cost escalation even before the contract is



Since we are dependent on indirect taxes than direct taxes, even the poor are taxed and their money is being used to build infrastructure for the rich.

NARENDAR PANI
Economist

awarded could mean the toll structure when the road is finally open for traffic after a four-year construction period could be much higher.

For comparison, a km of autorickshaw ride in Bengaluru today costs ₹18 and a km of cab ride is at ₹24. The toll charges alone for a trip in the tunnel road will be much higher as the commuter will also bear the fuel charges.

“Leave alone someone poor, two-wheelers and three-wheelers are not even allowed inside the tunnel roads. Even for a middle-class car owner like me, the proposed toll is very exorbitant,” says N.S. Mukunda, one of the petitioners challenging the project in the High Court of Karnataka.

Other projects

The draft DPR of the East-West Tunnel, spanning 19.2 km, has estimated a construction cost of ₹30,000 crore. The Special Purpose Vehicle will likely spend ₹1,500 crore per km of the East-West Tunnel.

A total of 13 elevated corridors, spanning 120.1 km, will cost ₹22,234.99 crore. Of them, the State will build nine flyovers of less than 10 km each at a cost of ₹4,755 crore and it will not be tolled.

Two other flyovers of 28 km and 18.50 km, at a cost of ₹7,577 crore, will be built with 40% Viability Gap Funding and 60% private investment like tunnel roads. Two other flyovers spanning 17.3 km and 27.2 km at a total cost of ₹9,902 crore will be completely built by the private concessionaire. These projects will be tolled for at least 20 years.

According to Prahallad, the plan is to set the toll charges at ₹10 per km for cars and ₹7 per km for two-wheelers. This will also mean that for a car user, commuting on the 28-km-long flyover connecting Yeshwantpur and K.R. Puram will cost ₹280 one-way, if there is no escalation further.

The Bengaluru Business Corridor (BBC) has taken up the construction of the 68-km-long PRR

Phase I, raising a loan of ₹27,000 crore from HUDCO. This road will also be tolled, though the toll structure is yet to be determined.

‘Projects not backed by data’

Prahallad argued that providing less-traffic expressways on toll is a practice across the world and that non-tolled alternatives will anyway continue to exist for those who do not want to pay.

However, what complicates this argument is the fact that the State is paying a 40% Viability Gap Funding for most of these projects and the State is funding the PRR completely all by itself. Only two flyovers are entirely funded by the concessionaire.

Economist Narendar Pani said the use of public money as Viability Gap Funding for these projects meant those who cannot afford to pay the toll and use the road pay for the infrastructure. “Since we are dependent on indirect taxes than direct taxes, even the poor are taxed and their money is being used to build infrastructure for the rich,” he said.

“Given the shortage of resources, has the government done an analysis of the necessity of this spending in the form of Viability Gap Funding. Such an evaluation should analyse the returns on these investments. Evidently, no such evaluation has happened. Many talk of welfare schemes as freebies to the poor, but these projects are essentially freebies for the rich,” Pani said.

Advocate and activist Vinay Sreenivasa, a petitioner challenging the tunnel road project in the NGT, said that public money for road projects where we need to further pay hefty tolls to ply on, “amounts to the poor subsidising the rich”. “We have been demanding a similar Viability Gap Funding for Bengaluru Metropolitan Transport Corporation (BMTTC) to make buses cheap and viable. It may even be a fraction of what Viability Gap Funding is being paid to these car-centric white elephant projects. But the government never gives it to BMTTC and it is opposed by many saying BMTTC must be self-sustaining. Why this double standard?” he asked.

The core of the problem is the exorbitant costs of these projects and the small fraction of the population it serves. One of the PILs flags this issue. “It is manifestly arbitrary as it costs ₹1,000 crore per km (versus ₹433 crore/km for Mumbai Coastal Road, ₹300 crore/km for Delhi Metro) while benefiting only 2.7% of the population (car owners)”, the petition says. However, the estimated cost of drilling a kilometre of tunnel road in North-South corridor is pegged at ₹1,170 crore and likely to go up to ₹1,500 crore for the East-West corridor.

Given the project exclusively permits four-wheelers while prohibiting two-wheelers (around 82% of the city’s 1.07 crore vehicles) and autorickshaws, it creates economic apartheid in

public infrastructure funded by all taxpayers, the petition argues.

Ashish Verma, convener, IISc Sustainable Transportation Lab, said none of these projects are backed by data or have scientific basis to act as a traffic solution. All grade separators only shift the bottleneck and network travel times only get worse. “With such high tolls, they will end up becoming ‘VIP green corridors’ for the rich, funded by all of us, even as it worsens traffic in the city,” he said.

Srikanth Vishwanathan, CEO, Janaagraha Centre for Citizenship and Democracy, and an expert in municipal finance, said most of these projects were both poor use of public finance and planning choices. “Actually, these are ad-hoc projects with no planning to talk of,” he added. “Either there has to be no Viability Gap Funding or no toll. You can’t have both,” he argued.

There are other concerns as well. B-SMILE has pledged the city’s advertisement and Premium FAR revenues to repay the loan taken towards the Viability Gap Funding of the tunnel roads project. “Future revenues of the corporations cannot be pledged by a parastatal. This is a violation of the autonomy of the municipal bodies, especially when there are no elected councils for six years now,” Srikanth said.

Can city roads be tolled?

Usually only State and National Highways outside city limits are tolled, and not roads inside the city. As of today, no road, barring parts of NICE Road within the city limits, in the Greater Bengaluru Authority (GBA) area is tolled. Even when private concessionaires have built roads like the International Airport Expressway within the city limits, the toll gate is outside the GBA area.

The tunnel roads and the four elevated corridors proposed to be developed by B-SMILE will be the first tolled roads within the GBA area. But can roads in the city be tolled?

Toll collection in the State is governed under the Karnataka Road User Fee (Determination of Rates and Collection) Rules, 2013, which states that a toll plaza should normally be located more than 10 km away from the boundary of a municipality or town.

But there are two exceptions. First, it can be closer than 10 km, given the executing authority can permit a toll plaza within 10 km of the town boundary if it records reasons in writing.

The exception that the B-SMILE is depending on is the second one - that “a toll plaza can be within 5 km or even inside the town where a section of a State Highway or a standalone structure is built primarily for the use of residents of that town or municipal area”.

In that situation, the toll plaza can be located within the municipal/town limits, or even within 5 km of those limits.

Here, the elevated corridor itself becomes a structure “specifically” being constructed for the residents of the town, which gives B-SMILE the authority to collect toll, Prahallad argued. He explained the rationale behind the toll stating that it is a structure that will connect two different parts of the city and it saves a good amount of time.

This comes even as the High Court of Karnataka recently observed that the Bangalore-Mysore Infrastructure Corridor (BMIC) project “appears to be one of the biggest scams in the State”. Saying it was fit case for an independent assessment and investigation, it expressed doubt about the conduct of such a probe “as the State itself is accomplice in allowing the project proponents (Nandi Infrastructure Corridor Enterprises and others) to earn huge profits illegally” by a host of means including “collecting huge toll in violation of the Frame Work Agreement”.

Ever since, former Chief Minister H.D. Kumaraswamy has been demanding that the State government take over NICE Road and immediately stop toll collection from road users on the stretch. The Congress government hasn’t responded yet to this specific demand. The issue was expected to come up for debate in the recent Karnataka Legislature session, which was a wash-out and no meaningful debate took place as the Opposition BJP demanded the resignation of a Minister and the government did not yield.



Activists stage a protest against the proposed underground tunnel road project at Lalbagh Botanical Garden in Bengaluru. ALLEN EGENUSE J.

TELANGANA



A CRPF constable stands guard in Pamunuru village, part of the Karreguttalu hills in Mulugu. Only seven families reside near the newly opened CRPF Forward Operating Base, after decades in the shadow of Maoist violence; (below) residents go about their daily chores. RAMAKRISHNA G.

And then there were seven in the silent hills

After decades of being caught between Maoists and the police, the seven families still living in Telangana’s Karreguttalu Hills are discovering life beyond fear. Once a formidable Maoist stronghold on the Telangana-Chhattisgarh border, the hills are now opening up with roads, security infrastructure and the promise of electricity and development. But return of the State’s writ also raises questions about the future of the forests and the communities that have lived here for decades. **Abhinay Deshpande** reports

Madvi Kamini has spent much of her life listening to the forest. For years, its silence was never reassuring. The dense foliage around her home in the Karreguttalu Hills could conceal Maoist cadres, security forces or landmines buried beneath the paths. Every knock, every unfamiliar movement and every journey beyond Pamunuru village in Mulugu district carried the possibility of danger.

The ‘annalu’ (Naxals), as the people of Pamunuru called them, would arrive at their homes with a message that was both familiar and cautionary: “*Manchiga bathakandi. Maa gurinchi police laku cheppakandi. Memu mee kosame unnām.*” (Live well. Don’t tell the police about us; we are here for you.)”

There was, however, little comfort in those words. The villagers had spent years caught between the Maoists and the police, fearing they could be killed by the former, targeted by the latter or arrested on suspicion of helping the banned outfit. “Many were arrested and spent over a year in jail too,” Kamini recalls.

Now, sitting behind a makeshift fence woven from branches outside her modest mud-and-wood home, Kamini, a mother of three, watches a different kind of change unfold. A bumpy mud road leads into the village. Seven houses sit amid the forest, each with a small national flag fluttering outside – something earlier disallowed by the Red Army. A newly opened CRPF Forward Operating Base, at 342 metres above sea level, stands nearby. Soon, the villagers expect electricity too.

It is a striking transformation for a place where, for decades, the Maoists held sway and the State struggled to establish a presence.

“For decades, we were caught between the Maoists and the police. Now, we are free from both,” says Kamini.

Her story is also the story of the Karreguttalu Hills, a rugged, densely forested stretch along the Telangana-Chhattisgarh border that once served as a Maoist stronghold but is now being opened up by roads and security forces after years of conflict.

With the help of the district administration and the CRPF, the police have laid a 33.5-km road from Murumuru to Tadapala village across the hills in a carefully executed road-opening operation through terrain heavily infested with landmines. The operation lasted nearly six months, and the road now extends to Tadapala, the last village on the border.

More than half a dozen villages, including Pamunuru, Jella, Doli, Tadapala and Chelimela, once existed across the Karreguttalu Hills, which stretch 55 km in length and 30 km in breadth. Today, only Pamunuru in Venkatapuram mandal remains inhabited.

Many villagers have either descended from the hills and settled in Venkatapuram mandal or moved to Chhattisgarh, some voluntarily and others after being forced out by the police, who suspected them of being Maoist militia members, informants or those involved in planting landmines.

“Forget about laying a road, we always

They (the Maoists) were confident nobody would enter the jungles and reach them. That changed with Operation Kagar, after which their guns fell silent. Now, we dominate the area. The main idea was to dominate, stabilise and develop the area.

SUDHIR RAMNATH KEKAN,
Mulugu SP

thought of entering Karreguttalu as a one-way trip to death. Maoists could ambush us, as they did in May 2025, when three personnel of the Greyhounds, the Telangana police’s elite anti-Naxal force, were killed. Their weapons were also taken away,” a police officer says.

After 2003, the Maoists began using Karreguttalu more extensively as a corridor between the Telangana plains and Dandakaranya, for press operations, meetings and supply dumps. A former Central Committee member says the area’s limited human movement and, at the time, absence of a communication network made it difficult for security forces to penetrate.

Mulugu Superintendent of Police Sudhir Ramnath Kekan describes the Karreguttalu Hills as a Maoist-free area today. He has visited parts of the hills that had remained inaccessible to security forces and forest officials for more than four decades.

“It was a safe haven for them. It was their bastion. They were confident nobody would enter the jungles and reach them. That changed with Operation Kagar, after which their guns fell silent,” he says. “Now, we dominate the area. The main idea was to dominate, stabilise and develop the area.”

Then Telangana Director General of Police B. Shivadhar Reddy became the first police chief of the State, and even of erstwhile Andhra Pradesh, to land on the hills on April 7 this year and interact with the people at Pamunuru.

But reclaiming the hills came with its own dangers. For the security forces opening the road, the biggest challenge was the extensive network of landmines laid by the Maoists.

Kekan says more than 200 improvised explosive devices (IEDs) and pressure mines were unearthed and defused while laying the 33.5-km road. Security forces also found 200 to 250 manholes near the road, in which armed cadres hid during the operation.

“The area was first sanitised using bomb detectors. Karreguttalu is one of the most challeng-

ing terrains,” adds Kekan, a 2018-batch IPS officer.

The IEDs were the Maoists’ principal line of defence. Even now, an estimated 400 to 500 active pressure mines remain scattered across the hills, he shares.

During Operation Kagar, they say, they could hear bombing and gunfire through the day and night for weeks. Security forces warned them not to step out of their homes while the Maoists cautioned them about landmines, asking them not to venture unnecessarily into the dense forest.

The 23 people living in Pamunuru’s seven houses, including nine men, six women and eight children, belong to the Muria community, an indigenous Adivasi Scheduled Tribe that originally hails from the Bastar region of Chhattisgarh.

Decades ago, the families migrated across the border in search of land for subsistence farming as their share of land in Chhattisgarh dwindled with expanding families. The border is a distinction they are neither aware of nor concerned about.

In Telangana, Murias are commonly referred to as Gutti Koyas, a term that offends many who feel it erases their original identity. Officials and experts say the hills were earlier inhabited by the Dorla, also known as Koya, a local tribal community. As Murias migrated from across the border, the Dorlas gradually moved to the plains.

“It is an unending cultural and identity debate. While the Muria population is around 7,000, Dorlas number around 60,000 to 70,000,” says an officer.

Between 1992 and 1998, the Dorlas moved down to avoid further conflict with the Murias. Jella, Doli and Tadapala each had four to five Muria families. They were allegedly asked to return to Chhattisgarh between 2021 and 2023 for supporting Maoist activities and sharing information about security-force movements. All three villages are now empty.

Sitting under a tree, Bheemaiah Madavi, among the first members of his tribe to migrate from Dabba in Chhattisgarh’s Dantewada district, recalls a life that has changed little over four decades. He does not know his exact age, has no Aadhaar card and has never benefited from any government welfare scheme. He first moved to Jella before migrating to Pamunuru, barely six kilometres away.

“The Naxals would come every month and take away our rice, pulses and other provisions. But we never told the police because we feared

they would kill us. Now, life is completely different and peaceful. We have a road, a bike, an autorickshaw, and a water tank in the village. Soon, we will get electricity, and other development will follow,” he says in broken Telugu heavily influenced by Gondi/Koya.

Like Bheemaiah, most villagers, except one or two in their 20s, do not know their exact age. They do not even keep track of how much they cultivate.

“We cultivate as much as we can or want. This forest is ours, and so is the land. We sell the surplus produce at the Venkatapuram market,” says Madakam Deva, whose two children live in Kamalapuram near Mulugu and two in Rekhpalli in the neighbouring State.

The police, however, allege that a majority of the villagers were Maoist sympathisers who supplied rations, passed on information about the movement of security forces, provided logistical support, helped plant IEDs and booby traps, and put up Maoist posters in the villages.

Muchaki Bheemaiah, 24, whose father Jogu is the oldest in the village, was arrested in 2020 for allegedly moving with the Maoists. He spent nearly 18 months in Khammam jail.

“He could have been recruited by the Maoists and killed in a police operation. He had the potential to become an active cadre, but we saved his life by arresting him,” a police officer says, as the youngster nods in agreement.

Muchaki says 22 cases were registered against him under the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act, 1967, with one recently quashed. He says he went into the jungle with banned party divisional committee member Sudhakar and stayed with the Maoists for two months.

“I used to carry gunny bags for them as they moved around. I also helped plant an IED near Pamunuru, which I later showed to the police after getting caught. In fact, I led them to the locations of four IEDs,” he says.

Eight people from Pamunuru and Palem were booked in the 22 cases. One of them, Madvi Kosa, died this summer after being released from prison, while another, Chundam Pandu, remains in jail.

During Operation Karreguttalu in April 2025, which lasted nearly 21 days, landmines and firing reportedly prevented security forces from reaching Maoist positions for about 17 days, injuring several commandos, he says. Nearly 500 Maoists, including Central Committee members, eventually sheltered in the hills. In the final operation, 31 were killed and the survivors retreated towards Telangana and southern Bastar.

The episode, the former cadre says, showed that difficult terrain could not protect guerrillas indefinitely without local support, even as police informers gradually strengthened. Hundreds of militia members helped Maoists lay landmines and booby traps, he recalls.

With roads seen as the first step towards development, the government is set to lay a BT (bituminous) road in the area, officials inform. The Forest Department is planning to promote forest tourism and trekking by developing premium cottages at Doli, the highest peak in the State.

At the same time, the forests are emerging as a site for major infrastructure projects. Megha Engineering and Infrastructures Ltd. (MEIL), Sun Petrochemicals and Greenko Energies Pvt. Ltd. have proposed pumped storage projects at Alubaka, Chalamalu and Ippagudem respectively, in the Godavari basin.

MoUs have already been signed for the three projects with proposed investments of ₹11,000 crore by MEIL, ₹45,500 crore by Sun Petrochemicals and ₹24,000 crore by Greenko Energies.

All three are located deep inside the forest. “These companies are just making way for more projects and mining in the region,” an official says.

That fear, Kamini says, lingered until early this year, when the last of the Maoists was either killed or surrendered to police. However, the villagers remain largely unaware of the projects planned in the area and of most of the State government’s welfare schemes.

